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A Theory of Polarization and Democratic Advantage

EVERY SEPTEMBER, IN a cavernous, wood-paneled room at the United Nations (UN) headquarters in New York City, delegates from member nations of the UN General Assembly (UNGA) gather to open a new session. At the outset of each the session, world leaders deliver remarks that are broadcast across the globe. At the opening of the forty-eighth session of the UNGA in September 1993, a new president of the United States took the podium. As the former governor of Arkansas, Bill Clinton had limited foreign policy experience before moving into the White House. His debut speech at the UNGA occurred at a time of both strife and optimism. In the early 1990s, political and social upheaval fueled brutal episodes of violence in Somalia and a newly independent Bosnia. But, elsewhere, new democracies were cautiously optimistic about the future. The dissolution of the Soviet Union contributed to a wave of democratization. Many democratic transitions across Eastern Europe, Latin America, Africa, and Asia had succeeded. Against this backdrop, Clinton focused his remarks on the virtues of democratic governance for international politics. In his trademark Southern drawl, Clinton announced, “Democracy is rooted in compromise, not conquest. It rewards tolerance, not hatred. Democracies rarely wage war on one another. They make more reliable partners in trade, in diplomacy, and in the stewardship of our global environment.”¹

More than a decade later, at the sixtieth session of the UNGA in September 2005, the world looked quite different. Terrorist attacks on the United States on September 11, 2001, led President George W. Bush to launch the Global War on Terrorism to combat Islamic extremism. Intense debate over U.S.-led

1. Clinton 1993.

wars in Afghanistan and Iraq shaped the atmosphere of a new UNGA session. Yet, some themes in Bush's address to the Assembly closely reflected those of his predecessor. Reiterating a similar sentiment about democracies, Bush remarked, "Democratic nations grow in strength because they reward and respect the creative gifts of their people. And democratic nations contribute to peace and stability because they seek national greatness in achievements of their citizens, not the conquest of their neighbors."²

The two speeches from the successive American presidents otherwise emphasized different threats and policy prescriptions. Clinton discussed dangers posed by nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons, making a strong case for nonproliferation. Bush focused on threats posed by transnational terrorism and urged other countries to unite in condemning state-sponsored terror. Clinton called upon the UN to expand peacekeeping operations. In contrast, Bush requested that the UN improve efficiency and implement cost-saving reforms.

Despite differences between the speeches, a common theme was the notion that democracies are both better at and better for international politics than nondemocracies. The idea that democracies are uniquely advantaged in foreign affairs and that a world full of democratic countries would be more just and more peaceful is shared by presidents and policymakers of both political parties in the United States. The theme recurs throughout inaugural addresses, speeches, and press releases from Republican and Democratic presidential administrations.

Such language is commonplace—and even cliché—in American foreign policy. But scholars who study international relations also refer to the concept of "democratic advantages" in the conduct of foreign affairs. This book draws on this democratic advantage tradition in international relations theory³ to highlight three advantages democracies have in international politics. The first is a stability advantage: democracies maintain consistent policies even when the leader or party in power changes. Second, democracies have a credibility advantage: they are better able to signal information about their objectives and intentions, making them more effective negotiators and more credible adversaries. Third, democracies have a reliability advantage: they commit to and comply with international agreements, making them more reliable partners. These advantages are interrelated and not perfectly separable. At times,

2. Bush 2005.

3. This tradition of thought is also referred to as "democratic triumphalism" (Desch 2002).

they reinforce one another. All three advantages arise from two systems of constraint on democratic leaders that make them accountable to the public and to an active political opposition.

Political scientists writing about democratic advantages have an ideal democracy in mind: a liberal democracy that not only has free and fair elections, but also domestic institutions that check political power and protect civil liberties. In reality, democracies are far more complex. A natural next step is to consider how these systems of constraint and the advantages they confer in foreign affairs differ across democracies. The purpose of this exercise is not to compare democratic foreign policy to autocratic foreign policy, but rather to explore variation in foreign policymaking within and across democracies.

Of course, democracies vary in many ways that could impact foreign affairs. They differ in their system of government (e.g., presidential, semipresidential, parliamentary), which affects how easy or difficult it is for a leader to change foreign policy. They differ in terms of their electoral systems (e.g., plurality, proportional representation) and the number of parties in government, which shapes whose foreign policy interests are represented and how. Democracies also differ in terms of their geographic location, resource endowments, political culture, and a host of other things. Any given democratic country is also prone to change over time. Demography shifts, economies expand and contract, media environments change, and policy issues become more or less politically salient. In short, many domestic factors impact foreign policy outcomes.

The goal of this book is to emphasize one important and overlooked domestic source of variation in democratic foreign policymaking: partisan polarization. Chapter 1 defined partisan polarization as increasing distance between major parties or coalitions of parties. Ideological polarization refers to the increasing divergence in policy preferences between political parties along ideological dimensions. Affective polarization refers to increasing social distance: the tendency for partisans to like members of their own party and to dislike members of opposing parties.

This book focuses on extreme polarization, or contexts in which there are high levels of both ideological and affective polarization. Chapter 1 explained that environments of extreme polarization are unique because they facilitate democratic erosion. While some degree of political contestation is characteristic of liberal democracies, as polarization becomes more extreme, the stakes of winning increase. Parties and their leaders begin to disregard democratic norms in order to see their preferred policies enacted. Partisan conflict extends

to other policy domains and institutions that were not previously politicized. Simultaneously, democratic constraints from the public, the media, and other actors within government are less effective in checking the power of political leaders.

Political scientists know a lot about how polarization affects democratic governance and society. However, its impact on foreign policy has been underappreciated. This chapter theorizes about those potential impacts. It begins by contextualizing the democratic advantage tradition of scholarship in international relations. It then describes systems of vertical and horizontal constraints and explains how they shape democratic foreign policymaking. Finally, it explores how extreme forms of polarization interact with these constraints to affect each of the democratic advantages. The main conclusion of this chapter is that extreme polarization can erode systems of constraint that advantage democracies in foreign affairs. On average, relative to less polarized times, during periods of high polarization, we should expect democratic foreign policymaking to be less stable and for democracies to be both less credible adversaries and less reliable allies.

2.1 The Democratic Advantage Tradition and Its Critics

In 1831, a French political philosopher named Alexis de Tocqueville arrived in the United States to conduct research on the American penitentiary system. Over nine months, Tocqueville and his travel companion visited cities and towns all over the country, collecting information for their report on prison reform for France. Yet, Tocqueville left the United States with a much broader range of observations on American politics and society. One conclusion Tocqueville drew from his study was that democracies were “decidedly inferior” in matters of diplomacy and foreign affairs.⁴ He believed institutional features of democratic government were responsible for fickle and shortsighted foreign policy. Tocqueville noted: “[A] democracy finds it difficult to coordinate the details of a great undertaking and to fix on some plan and carry it through with determination in spite of obstacles. It has little capacity for combining measures in secret and waiting patiently for the result.”⁵

4. Tocqueville 1835.

5. Tocqueville 1835, 228–230.

Tocqueville's widely cited⁶ critiques of democratic foreign policy reflected the general consensus on the subject for a long time. In the United States, for example, through much of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, policy-makers and intellectuals expressed concerns about democratic accountability and the volatile nature of public opinion. George Kennan—a diplomat and architect of U.S. containment policy during the Cold War—was described as viewing democratic public opinion as “inevitably unstable, unserious, subjective, emotional, and simple-minded.”⁷ Intellectuals like Gabriel Almond and Walter Lippmann argued that the public was especially ill-equipped to hold leaders to account on foreign policy issues.⁸

But, in the past few decades, political scientists started to challenge this conventional thinking about democratic foreign policy. Beginning in the 1980s and 1990s, a tradition of scholarship in international relations emerged that suggested the opposite: democracies were perhaps advantaged in foreign affairs relative to their nondemocratic counterparts. Scholars in this tradition observed that institutional features of democracies that constrained political power had positive downstream consequences for foreign policy-making. It is not a coincidence that scholarship emphasizing the benefits of liberal democracy proliferated following the so-called third wave of democratization that coincided with the decline of communism and the end of the Cold War.⁹ Researchers in international relations sought to investigate whether democracies were advantaged by quantifying and systematically comparing foreign policy outcomes in democracies to the same outcomes in nondemocracies.¹⁰

Today, the democratic advantage tradition is a cornerstone of international relations theory. The concept is most often associated with *democratic peace theory*: the tendency for democracies to resolve disputes with one another peacefully. This theory argues that democratic publics and their leaders have

6. Other researchers have similarly contextualized the democratic advantage tradition as a response to longstanding critiques of democracy from Tocqueville and others (see, e.g., Leeds and Mattes 2022; Kroenig 2020; Schultz and Weingast 2003).

7. Chalberg 1989, 485.

8. Almond 1950, 1956; Lippmann 1922, 1955. See, also, characterizations of the “Almond–Lippmann consensus” (e.g., Holsti 1992) about public opinion and foreign policy.

9. See, e.g., Huntington 1991; Fukuyama 1992.

10. See, e.g., Gaubatz 1996; Martin 2000; Lipson 2003; Mansfield, Milner, and Rosendorff 2002; Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel 2009; Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll 2015; Leeds and Mattes 2022; Reiter and Stam 2002; Russett 1993; Schultz 2001a.

normative commitments to peace¹¹ and domestic institutions that facilitate nonviolent dispute resolution.¹² Democracies that do engage in fighting are also thought to be more effective on the battlefield.¹³ In their book *Democracies at War*, Dan Reiter and Allan Stam argue that democratic advantages in fighting come from both selection and performance. Because democratic leaders fear the electoral consequences of losing wars, they are more selective about the wars they fight. An emphasis on individual rights in democratic societies makes soldiers more motivated to fight for their country, further improving military performance.

Yet the advantages democracies have in foreign affairs extend beyond peace and conflict. Some researchers describe economic advantages democracies have when selling bonds or accessing credit.¹⁴ Others refer to advantages democracies have in geopolitical competition when compared to their authoritarian rivals.¹⁵ Still others apply the term to a general set of advantages democracies have across foreign policy domains from militarized conflict to diplomacy to economic growth.¹⁶

Today, the democratic advantage tradition is arguably a dominant perspective among international relations scholars. As with all traditions, however, there are critics of this body of scholarship. The first line of critique, associated with the tradition of *realism* in international relations theory, echoes earlier thinking on democratic foreign policy. The main argument is that democracies do not behave that differently from autocracies because all countries seek to maximize their power and security. Realist scholars believe that when push comes to shove, democracies will not adhere to liberal norms in international politics. Rather, they will make decisions on the basis of their national security interests. The implication of realist arguments is that we should not expect democracies to be any more cooperative or less conflict prone in international politics than their autocratic peers.¹⁷ Democracies also should not inherently be more credible than autocracies or more reliable as alliance partners.¹⁸

11. Doyle 1983; Maoz and Russett 1993; Russett 1993; Tomz and Weeks 2013.

12. Bueno de Mesquita and Lalman 1992; Lipson 2003; Schultz 1998.

13. Lake 1992; Reiter and Stam 2002.

14. Beaulieu, Cox, and Saiegh 2012; DisGuiseppe and Shea 2015; Schultz and Weingast 2003.

15. Kroenig 2020.

16. Hyde and Saunders 2020.

17. See, e.g., Gartzke 2007; Gowa 1999; Mearsheimer 1990; Rosato 2003.

18. Downes and Sechser 2012; Gartzke and Gleditsch 2004.

A second line of critique of the democratic advantage thesis focuses on authoritarian advantages. Researchers in this tradition emphasize that many nondemocratic countries also have vertical and horizontal constraints on their leaders.¹⁹ These constraints can functionally give some nondemocracies the same advantages that democracies have when making foreign policy. For example, authoritarian regimes that have higher levels of accountability to the public may be more stable and less likely to initiate conflict.²⁰ Some types of authoritarian regimes are also able to send signals in international politics that are just as credible as those issued by democracies.²¹

This book raises a third critique of the democratic advantage thesis. It argues that both historically and presently, democracies have faced unique internal challenges that can undermine the institutional constraints governments have on their leaders. The internal challenge this book focuses on is extreme polarization. In this vein, this book does not overturn the democratic advantage thesis but rather argues that we should expect variation among democracies in terms of their behavior in foreign policy based on their level of polarization. To understand how and why this occurs, this chapter identifies the systems of constraint that advantage democracies and explores how polarization affects them.

2.2 Democratic Constraints and Foreign Affairs

The democratic advantages that are the focus of this book come from two sets of constraints on political power found in liberal democracies.²² The first is a system of *vertical constraints* that make democratic leaders accountable to the public. The main way that publics constrain democratic leaders is through regular elections. Elections give voters opportunities to express their satisfaction or dissatisfaction with the individual or political party in power. In anticipation of future elections, democratic leaders have incentives to make foreign policy choices that reflect the will of the public.

19. See, e.g., Hyde and Saunders 2020 for a discussion of how both democratic and autocratic leaders can be subject to common domestic constraints.

20. Weeks 2012, 2014.

21. Weiss 2013, 2014; Weeks 2008.

22. These democratic constraints are also referred to as systems of horizontal and vertical accountability (Lührmann, Marquardt, and Mechkova 2020). This book uses the terms “constraint” and “accountability” interchangeably.

Democratic leaders are likely to be most responsive to vertical constraints when the public is willing and able to assess the leader's policy choices. In *The Ambivalent Partisan*, Howard Lavine, Christopher Johnston, and Marco Steenbergen argue that democratic accountability is strongest when citizens can set aside their partisan commitments in evaluating politicians and their respective policies.²³ In foreign affairs, electoral accountability should dissuade leaders from making choices that lead to bad foreign policy outcomes. Politicians who mishandle international crises or lead their publics into devastating, unpopular wars are unlikely to be reelected. In extreme cases, they can face public pressure to resign. Consider the fate of Prime Minister Anthony Eden in the UK. In the 1956 Suez Crisis, Egyptian president Gamal Abdel Nassar had nationalized the Suez Canal, a critical waterway that facilitated trade between Asia and Europe. After much deliberation, Prime Minister Eden responded by launching a joint invasion of Egypt with Israel and France. The invasion was poorly executed and had disastrous political and economic consequences in Great Britain. Eden's mishandling of the crisis contributed to a wave of public disapproval that led to his resignation in 1957.²⁴

By contrast, foreign policy decisions widely supported by the public boost a democratic leader's popularity and can be influential in their future electoral prospects. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy skyrocketed in popularity after he stood firm in response to Russian President Vladimir Putin's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022. Polling from the Kyiv International Institute of Sociology showed that, in 2022, 84 percent of Ukrainians trusted President Zelenskyy. The following year, after a largely unsuccessful counteroffensive campaign against Russia, the majority of Ukrainians still supported Zelenskyy but trust in the president had declined to 62 percent.²⁵

Even leaders who are not facing reelection may still be responsive to public opinion on key foreign policy issues. Democratic leaders pay attention to public sentiments because they care about their image or how they are portrayed in the press and popular culture. They take public opinion into consideration out of concern for their legacy or the future of their political party. Surveys show that democratic politicians care what the public thinks about foreign policy, even when it comes to "high stakes" national security issues. For example, in a survey experiment in Israel, political scientists Michael Tomz, Jessica

23. Lavine, Johnston, and Steenbergen 2012.

24. James 1987.

25. Hrushetskyi 2023.

Weeks, and Keren Yarhi-Milo found that providing members of the Israeli Knesset information about public attitudes toward military strikes on terrorist bases influences those ministers' opinions about using military force.²⁶ A similar study of UK members of Parliament showed that the politicians were responsive to public opinion on the question of whether or not the UK should maintain military presence in the South China Sea.²⁷

The second set of constraints on democratic leaders is a system of *horizontal constraints*. These intragovernmental constraints ensure that democratic leaders are accountable to other actors and institutions within government. In foreign affairs, horizontal constraints operate in many forms. They can arise through a separate legislature like the U.S. Congress or an independent judiciary that checks executive power.²⁸ Horizontal constraints can also arise from within the executive. Democratic leaders can be constrained by other elites, advisors, and bureaucrats in their own administrations who shape foreign policy decision-making.²⁹

Because this book focuses on partisan polarization, the main horizontal constraint I emphasize is the political opposition. In democracies, the *political opposition* is the major political party, or coalition of parties, that opposes the incumbent party and intends to challenge it for power in future elections.³⁰ Opposition parties use many tools to constrain leaders. At the extremes are tools that can remove leaders or their parties from office. These include no-confidence votes or impeachment proceedings that take place in national legislatures. Opposition parties played critical roles in ousting Paraguayan President Fernando Lugo in 2012, Brazilian President Dilma Rousseff in 2016, and South Korean President Park Geun-hye in 2017.³¹

Foreign policy disasters can prompt an opposition party to remove or attempt to remove an incumbent leader. Interestingly, one of the earliest no-confidence votes was rooted in a poor foreign policy outcome. During an expensive and protracted war across the Atlantic in America's thirteen colonies, American revolutionary forces defeated the British, who surrendered

26. Tomz, Weeks, and Yarhi-Milo 2020.

27. Chu and Recchia 2022.

28. Howell and Pevehouse 2005, 2007; Kriner and Shickler 2016; Staton and Moore 2011.

29. Halperin and Clapp 2007; Jost 2024; Saunders 2015, 2022, 2024.

30. My focus on opposition parties does not mean that other actors within government are not important to foreign policy. Historically, for example, independent courts have played a critical role in constraining the power of democratic leaders.

31. Ginsburg, Huq, and Landau 2021.

in Yorktown, Virginia. The British defeat propelled anti-war sentiment in the House of Commons and led to a vote of no confidence in Prime Minister Lord North and his cabinet, who subsequently resigned.³²

Beyond removing or threatening to remove democratic leaders, the opposition party has other ways to influence foreign policy. In many democracies, the political opposition plays a formal role in making foreign policy decisions through the legislative process. Entering into international treaties or issuing declarations of war often necessitates some input from a legislative body. In Denmark, the power to deploy military troops lies with the Danish parliament, the Folketing. In Uruguay, the legislative branch—the Asamblea General—authorizes the president's declaration of war. In Japan, the Diet must grant the prime minister approval to deploy troops within three weeks of the deployment.³³ These arrangements make it unlikely that consequential foreign policy decisions will be enacted purely along partisan lines.

The political opposition also constrains democratic leaders informally. Opposition parties hold hearings, conduct inquiries, shape media coverage, or influence public opinion.³⁴ One of the most powerful things that the opposition can do is to subject leaders to scrutiny. During U.S. President Ronald Reagan's second term in office (1985–1989), a scandal known as the Iran-Contra Affair prompted the U.S. Congress to investigate the Republican administration. White House officials covertly sold arms to the Iranian government and used the revenue to fund the Contras, a Nicaraguan rebel group. Democratic legislators chaired the investigative committees in both the House of Representatives and the Senate, releasing a damning report about White House involvement in the scandal. In theory, anticipation of this type of blowback spearheaded by an opposition party should give democratic leaders incentives to avoid foreign policy decisions that will lead to bad outcomes.

Systems of vertical and horizontal constraint are common to liberal democracies, irrespective of their system of government or electoral system. These democratic constraints consist of formal institutions, such as elections or impeachment processes, that check executive power. But they also include informal institutions that constrain democratic leaders indirectly. Informal institutions and norms play an especially important role in foreign affairs,

32. Whiteley 1996.

33. Wagner, Peters, and Glahn 2010.

34. Baum and Potter 2015; Howell and Pevehouse 2005, 2007; Kriner and Shickler 2016.

where executives tend to have more discretion than in domestic policy. These systems of constraint give rise to three advantages democracies have in foreign affairs relative to nondemocracies: a stability advantage, a credibility advantage, and a reliability advantage.

2.3 The Stability Advantage

Between 1930 and 1976, six military coups interrupted brief periods of democratic rule in Argentina. Throughout this era, political instability created volatile economic conditions. In the final coup d'état in 1976, a right-wing military dictatorship overthrew Isabel Perón, who presided over Argentina after the death of her husband Juan Perón. The Peróns were left-wing populists whose support was concentrated in Argentina's lower and middle classes. After ousting Perón, the military dictatorship began a systematic campaign of state-sponsored terror. This dark period of Argentinian politics, known as *La Guerra Suecia* or the Dirty War, resulted in the death and disappearance of tens of thousands of political dissidents who opposed the Argentine dictatorship.³⁵

The right-wing military juntas that ruled Argentina from 1976 to 1983 differed on many dimensions from the left-wing Peronistas, including in their foreign policy. Unlike their predecessors, they supported other right-wing dictatorships in Latin America and maintained close relations with the U.S. government, which endorsed the 1976 coup d'état.³⁶ Reflecting conservative, neoliberal economic principles, the junta pursued free market economic policies that increased Argentina's foreign debt.³⁷ And, in 1982, the junta embarked on a misguided land grab, invading the British-owned Falklands Island off the Argentine coast. Many researchers characterize the Falklands War as a diversionary conflict, intended to distract from economic and political problems in Argentina.³⁸

After the UK defeated Argentina in the Falklands War, mounting social and economic unrest, coupled with international scrutiny of the dictatorship's human rights violations, put increasing pressure on the military junta, which lost power in 1983. Since then, three political parties in Argentina have held

35. Brennan 2018.

36. Osorio 2021.

37. Munck 1985.

38. Oakes 2012. Although, see Fravel 2010.

the presidency.³⁹ These parties differ in terms of their economic and foreign policy preferences. However, democratic transition in Argentina brought considerable stability to the country's foreign policy relative to the previous era. The contrast between these periods in Argentina's history illustrates a stability advantage that democracies have relative to nondemocracies.

The first advantage democracies have in foreign affairs is that they maintain relatively stable foreign policies. By relatively stable, I mean that foreign policy in democracies does not tend to abruptly shift. We understand this pattern based on studies that analyze the relationship between regime type and foreign policy positioning over time.⁴⁰ Although leadership turnover in democracies is more frequent than in autocracies, leadership changes are regularized.⁴¹ Democratic leaders are less likely to be removed through irregular means such as a military coup, assassination, or exile.⁴² This is important because leaders who anticipate an unpleasant fate upon removal from power engage in more volatile policymaking. Desperate autocrats may attempt to stave off domestic challengers by continuing a conflict abroad or initiating new conflicts.⁴³ But, in healthy democracies with contested elections, leadership turnover is inevitable. Democracies expect future turnover and can work to minimize the uncertainty that accompanies leadership transitions.

The stability advantage arises in part because, in democracies, the foreign policy preferences of major parties tend to be quite similar. Why? Both vertical and horizontal constraints in democracies work to keep foreign policy consistent. Vertical constraints shape the foreign policy preferences of political parties and their respective candidates in two key ways. First, in many democracies, electoral accountability tends to make parties pursue policies consistent with the "median voter" in the electorate. In his famous article, "An Economic Theory of Political Action in Democracy," Anthony Downs builds on theories of group decision-making to develop a spatial theory of voting.⁴⁴ In this conception, we can think about ideological positions of political parties arrayed on a single dimension, such as a right-left or conservative-liberal spectrum. Each voter has their own position on the ideological spectrum,

39. At the time of writing, these three parties were Unión Civica Radical, Partido Justicialista, and Propuesta Republicana.

40. Leeds and Mattes 2022; Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll 2015; Smith 2016.

41. Riker 1982; Gaubatz 1996.

42. Goemans, Gleditsch, and Chiozza 2009.

43. Chiozza and Goemans 2011; Goemans 2000.

44. Downs 1957. See also Black 1948; Hotelling 1929.

referred to as their ideal point. Voters select the party whose positions are closest (i.e., most similar) to their ideal point. If parties are competing for a majority of votes, under certain assumptions, they tend to converge toward the ideal point of the median voter in the electorate. This insight, referred to as the median voter theorem or the median voter model, applies most directly to two-party, winner-take-all democratic systems.

Although much research in political science introduces complications to the median voter model, the central implication is straightforward. In democracies with competitive elections, candidates vying for nationwide office have few incentives to run on a platform that reflects extreme views that are dissimilar from those of the median voter. If foreign policy is salient for electoral politics, successive democratic leaders in the same country over time are unlikely to adopt radically different foreign policy preferences.

Second, and closely related, vertical constraints make democratic leaders more likely to pursue foreign policies that provide public goods. In their book *The Logic of Political Survival*, a group of four political scientists—Bruce Bueno de Mesquita, Alastair Smith, Randolph Siverson, and James Morrow—introduce the concept of *selectorate theory* to explain how electoral accountability results in better foreign policy outcomes in democracies relative to autocracies.⁴⁵ Selectorate theory starts with the premise that leaders or parties from all regime types wish to remain in power. However, regime types differ in the size of their selectorate (the total population involved in selecting a leader) and the size of their winning coalition (the subset of the selectorate needed for a leader to maintain power). In autocracies, leaders must appease a small group of supporters to maintain political control. For example, an autocrat may need to co-opt other political elites in order to dissuade them from staging a coup. But, in democracies, leaders need to secure the support of a majority or plurality of the electorate. To do so, they pursue policies that benefit a large portion of the selectorate. Bueno de Mesquita and coauthors explain that because democratic leaders are accountable to a large group of people rather than a small group of elites, they are better at providing public goods.

The logic of selectorate theory explains why democratic leaders are less beholden to special interests relative to autocrats when they make foreign policy.⁴⁶ When making trade policy, for example, democracies tend to pursue economic openness and international cooperation because reducing barriers

45. Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2002.

46. McGillivray and Smith 2008; Bobick and Smith 2013.

to trade improves national welfare overall.⁴⁷ If leaders only needed to appease a small winning coalition to stay in power, they might enact protectionist policies that advantage their core supporters. When a new autocrat comes to power with different core supporters, foreign policy will shift dramatically. In their book *Punishing the Prince*, Fiona McGillivray and Alastair Smith draw on selectorate theory to explain how foreign policy remains consistent in democracies despite leadership turnover.⁴⁸ The researchers demonstrate across many issues—including crisis bargaining, trade, and sovereign debt—that leadership turnover in democracies tends to have little impact on foreign relations.

Beyond vertical constraints, horizontal constraints also reinforce stability in democratic foreign policy. Recall that a key horizontal constraint in democracies is the presence of an active political opposition. In healthy democracies, politicians know that their political party will not remain in power in perpetuity. How parties behave when they are in power will have implications for how they are treated by political opponents who assume leadership positions in the future.

Political economist Alberto Alesina formalizes this logic.⁴⁹ His model begins with a political system in which two parties compete for the median voter. Without the expectation of future elections, political parties have an incentive to campaign on a moderate policy platform but, once elected, “defect” by implementing their preferred, more extreme policy. In this scenario, parties are unable to credibly commit to a more moderate policy. However, Alesina argues that the expectation of future elections can induce parties to cooperate by creating a “partisan truce” in which both parties commit to, and implement, the moderate policy that benefits society as a whole. One example Alesina uses is monetary policy. Since parties expect future electoral cycles, they tend to avoid manipulating monetary policy to spur economic growth in advance of an upcoming election. Instead, they create nonpartisan institutions, like independent central banks, to govern monetary policy. This tacit cooperation prevents economic volatility and benefits the public.

Other researchers, like political scientist Joanne Gowa, point out that a similar partisan truce exists in national security.⁵⁰ If there were no future

47. Mansfield, Milner, and Rosendorff 2002.

48. McGillivray and Smith 2008.

49. Alesina 1987, 1988.

50. Gowa 1998.

elections, parties might try to increase public support by initiating international disputes. Disputes could create a “rally round the flag” effect, boosting an incumbent’s popularity during a security crisis.⁵¹ But, using data from the United States, Gowa finds no correlation between presidential election years and entrance into international disputes. She concludes that these results are “consistent with the existence of a tacit partisan truce, a self-enforcing agreement between the parties to abstain from using force abroad to prosecute political battles at home.”⁵² In other words, the inevitability of future leadership constrains the actions of the leader in power and the opposition party.

Tacit partisan cooperation can be uniquely beneficial in foreign affairs. For one, good foreign policymaking requires long time horizons. Since international politics does not stop when leaders exit office, politicians must prepare for foreign policies to extend beyond their term. Successful foreign policymaking also requires substantial technical expertise. To make strategic decisions, leaders rely on experts who are deeply knowledgeable about other countries and maintain relationships with foreign leaders.

Recognizing the necessity of insulating foreign policy from domestic partisan pressures, politicians invest in nonpartisan institutions that create continuity in foreign policy. These include ministries and agencies that manage diplomatic relations with other countries and are substantially staffed by career civil servants.⁵³ They also include defense agencies and professional militaries whose day-to-day operations are unaffected by leader turnover. And they include intelligence agencies like the Central Intelligence Agency in the United States, the Australian Secret Intelligence Service, and the Bundesnachrichtendienst in Germany, which collect and analyze information about national security issues. Well-designed national security bureaucracies facilitate better foreign policy decision-making.⁵⁴ In liberal democracies, many of these institutions act as another horizontal constraint on executive power and are considered above the fray of traditional partisan politicking.

51. Mueller 1970, 20.

52. Gowa 1998, 307.

53. Some foreign ministries, like the UK’s Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office and the Japanese Ministry of Foreign Affairs, for instance, are managed by career civil servants. Others, like the U.S. State Department and the French Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs, are run by political appointees, but career civil servants make up a significant portion of the daily functioning of the agencies.

54. Jost 2024.

Together, both vertical and horizontal constraints contribute to a stability advantage by keeping the foreign policies of democracies consistent over time. Vertical constraints contribute to foreign policy stability by inducing responsiveness to a median voter, deterring democratic politicians from taking extreme foreign policy positions. Vertical constraints also keep democratic leaders accountable to the electorate as a whole rather than to particular interest groups. Horizontal constraints contribute to the stability advantage by giving the executive and opposition parties incentives to uphold a tacit partisan truce in foreign policy. The inevitable alternation of power in democracies keeps foreign policy positions of the parties consistent and provides incentives for politicians to invest in nonpartisan institutions integral to foreign policymaking. The lack of similar constraints in autocracies means that irregular leader turnover in these countries in theory produces more volatile foreign policy.

2.3.1 Polarization and the Erosion of Democratic Stability

How, then, does extreme polarization affect the stability advantage? I argue that, as polarization becomes more extreme, it interacts with both sets of democratic constraints to create different dynamics that, on average, lead to more volatility in foreign policy when the party controlling the executive switches.

Consider first how polarization interacts with vertical constraints. In theory, electoral accountability should induce politicians to compete over a median voter and provide public goods that maximize national welfare. But, in highly polarized contexts, vertical constraints may not necessarily give politicians these same incentives. For one, extreme polarization can make politicians more likely to appeal to an ideologically extreme base of core supporters rather than to a median voter in the electorate. To understand this logic, consider the distinction between two strategies that political parties use when campaigning. On the one hand, a party can opt to mobilize its base by targeting members of the electorate who are already likely to support that party with the goal of increasing turnout among its supporters. On the other hand, a party can canvas broadly with the goal of persuading potential voters who do not already support the party to vote for its candidate.

In heavily polarized democratic systems, a strategy focused on mobilization becomes more appealing to candidates than a strategy focused on persuasion. Cross-national analyses of polarization and election campaigns show

that parties in more polarized democracies have fewer incentives to canvas broadly.⁵⁵ In these contexts, persuading voters to abandon their ideological commitments to vote for a different party becomes difficult. Parties instead focus on messaging that energizes their core supporters or special interests associated with their party rather than on messages crafted to appeal to a median voter.

Shifting messaging strategies in contemporary U.S. presidential campaigns reflect this dynamic. In the United States, partisan sorting within the electorate resulted in greater coherence between ideology and partisan identity.⁵⁶ For national elections, it is now increasingly difficult to persuade voters to vote for candidates from the opposing party. Experimental research on election outcomes shows that it is very challenging for political campaigns to convince voters to change their minds.⁵⁷ At times, persuasive campaigning can even backfire.⁵⁸

In lieu of tailoring policies toward a median voter, candidates may opt for messaging that energizes and mobilizes their political base. In foreign policy, this messaging sometimes includes controversial or divisive statements. In the 2016 U.S. presidential election, for example, Republican candidate Donald Trump made fiery rhetoric about China a centerpiece of his campaign. While campaigning in Indiana, he exclaimed, “We can’t continue to allow China to rape our country, and that’s what we’re doing. It’s the greatest theft in the history of the world.”⁵⁹ Trump used similar inflammatory language during national debates and election rallies to paint China as a major foreign threat and criticize their trade practices. Other Republican candidates followed suit.

Second, high levels of affective polarization in the public can fuel polarization on salient foreign policy issues, especially when these issues coincide with electoral cycles. This process could be considered a form of *conflict extension*, which occurs when party activists and ideologues extend partisan conflict into policy areas that were not previously politicized.⁶⁰ This can happen in affectively polarized settings, where politicians have electoral incentives to

55. Karp 2012. This is most likely in systems where voting is not compulsory and voter turnout is relatively low. See, e.g., Karp and Banducci 2007.

56. Levendusky 2009.

57. Kalla and Broockman 2018.

58. Bailey, Hopkins, and Rodgers 2016.

59. BBC News 2016.

60. Layman and Carsey 2002; Layman et al. 2010.

strongly disagree with (or even to mock or deride) positions championed by the opposite party. It could be especially tempting for politicians to manipulate public opinion in foreign policy, where the electorate tends to have less information relative to domestic policy.⁶¹

Of course, some foreign policy issues are more prone to politicization than others. Areas of foreign policy linked to both social and partisan identities are among those most vulnerable to polarization. Consider, for example, the politicization of foreign policy that followed the rise of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), a right-wing Hindu party, in Indian politics. After the 1947 partition of India and Pakistan, the relatively centrist Indian National Congress (known as the Congress Party) dominated Indian politics for decades. In the 1980s, the BJP emerged as a Hindu nationalist party against a backdrop of growing sectarian violence between Hindus and Muslims. The BJP won a majority of the Lok Sabha, the lower house of the Indian Parliament, in the 2014 national elections, and the leader of the campaign, Narendra Modi, became prime minister.

Prime Minister Modi's ascent is associated with increased social and political polarization in India.⁶² As polarization grew, national security policy also became more politicized. Hindu nationalism shaped the BJP's counterterrorism policies and more hawkish stance toward its neighbor Pakistan, a Muslim-majority country. A report published by the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace warned about politicization of security issues in India, which are "discussed in hyper-nationalistic rhetorical terms. For instance, the BJP and the Congress Party respectively wield terms like 'jihadi terror' and 'Hindu terror' to try to cast their opponents in the worst light possible."⁶³

Such examples illustrate how vertical constraints are unlikely to moderate political leaders in a highly polarized democracy. Instead, responsiveness to a partisan public may make politicians more likely to take extreme positions and to instrumentalize negative partisanship in foreign affairs. Even if foreign policy is not central to a country's main political cleavage, foreign policy issues that become salient in a polarized context can be politicized when championed by a partisan figure or group. These attitudes should in theory be reflected in public opinion polling. As chapter 4 will explore, some issues in foreign affairs are more susceptible to politicization than others. But, overall,

61. Zaller 1992; Guisinger and Saunders 2017.

62. Masih and Slater 2019.

63. Sahoo 2020, 17.

we should expect greater foreign policy divergence to follow from extreme polarization as partisan conflict extends to foreign affairs.

Stability Hypothesis 1: As polarization becomes more extreme, domestic partisan conflict is more likely to extend into foreign affairs.

Extreme polarization also impacts the horizontal constraints that contribute to the stability advantage. In nonpolarized contexts, the inevitability of party turnover can induce a partisan truce between the opposition and executive parties in foreign affairs.⁶⁴ Given the importance of long time horizons in foreign policymaking, parties have incentives both to not implement extreme policies and to invest in institutions that keep foreign policy relatively nonpartisan. As polarization becomes more extreme, however, short-term political incentives outweigh long-term considerations. Two processes in particular contribute to the erosion of the partisan truce in foreign affairs.

For one, politicians that hold more ideologically extreme positions have more reasons to defect from a partisan truce by campaigning on and enacting extreme foreign policies. These incentives could come from increases in affective polarization and negative partisanship, which make politicians eager to differentiate themselves from the opposite party. They could also come from deeply held ideological commitments, which manifest to varying degrees in aspects of foreign affairs. In Hungary, popular discontent with the leadership of the left-wing Hungarian Socialist Party led to the rise of right-wing Fidesz under Viktor Orbán in 2010. Prime Minister Orbán's conservative values and populist tendencies are reflected in his foreign policy positions: he held more anti-immigrant and Euroskeptical views relative to his predecessors. Once in office, Orbán acted on these policy positions, reshaping the nature of Hungary's foreign relations by strengthening relations with China and Russia relative to the EU.

Another way politicians could erode the partisan truce in foreign affairs is by politicizing foreign policy institutions. In extremely polarized societies, attacks on nonpartisan government institutions, including foreign policy institutions like defense agencies and intelligence agencies, become more common.⁶⁵ If an incumbent leader perceives an ostensibly nonpartisan institution to be aligned with the opposition party, they may relentlessly criticize the

64. See, e.g., Alesina 1987, 1988; Gowa 1998.

65. While not the focus of this book, a similar argument can be made about the politicization of nonstate institutions that constrain executive power, such as the media and civil society.

institution or use it as a scapegoat for foreign policy failures. If instead the institution is aligned with the executive party, it may be politicized in the process of helping a leader entrench their power.

One example of this is growing concern about the politicization of defense agencies and militaries in highly polarized societies. In an ideal liberal democracy, professionalized militaries are nonpartisan; they are not solely aligned with one leader or political party. It is no coincidence, however, that many polarized countries have fraught civil–military relations. Consider the case of Venezuela under left-wing Presidents Hugo Chávez and Nicolás Maduro of the United Socialist Party of Venezuela. During their respective presidential administrations, Venezuelan politics was sharply polarized along socioeconomic lines, reflecting support for, or opposition to, Chávez’s socialist policies.⁶⁶ Chávez took a number of steps that politicized the military. In reorganizing Venezuela’s armed forces, the distinction between the military and other domestic state security institutions was blurred. Chávez displayed favoritism by promoting officers who expressed loyalty to his administration.⁶⁷ He also increased the visibility of military officers holding prestigious political positions, including positions in the president’s cabinet.⁶⁸

While Venezuela poses an extreme case, researchers are concerned that polarization could undermine civil–military relations in democracies. In the United States, for example, politicization of the military and the defense establishment may undermine its credibility as a nonpartisan institution.⁶⁹ In *Thanks for Your Service*, political scientist Peter Feaver explains that the combination of high public confidence in the U.S. military and a polarized public makes it tempting for political leaders to politicize the military for partisan gain.⁷⁰ These examples suggest that in a polarized climate, as the stakes of winning increase, parties have fewer incentives to maintain a tacit partisan truce in foreign policy. Short-term incentives for political gain outweigh longer-term considerations about the stability of foreign policy. Politicians enact more ideologically extreme policies that energize their core supporters

66. Pilar, García-Guadilla, and Mallen 2019.

67. Trinkunas 2022.

68. Perera 2019.

69. See, e.g., concerns raised by scholars of civil–military relations: Beliakova 2021; Brooks 2020; Feaver 2023b; Golby 2021; Krebs, Ralston, and Rapport 2023; Lee 2022; Robinson 2022.

70. Feaver 2023b.

and may resort to politicization of nonpartisan foreign policy institutions to their political advantage.

Stability Hypothesis 2: As polarization becomes more extreme, politicians are more likely to politicize the foreign policy bureaucracy.

In extremely polarized societies, changing preferences of both the public and politicians undermine the stability advantage. By definition, as ideological polarization increases, political parties are more inclined to disagree on policy. Yet, even when there are sharp disagreements on domestic policy, foreign affairs may still be insulated from the partisan divide. What differs about environments of extreme polarization is that the effects of affective and ideological polarization compound and reinforce one another. In such contexts, partisan conflict is more likely to extend to foreign policy.

Affective polarization further gives politicians incentives to campaign on reversing policies of the opposite party to mobilize their core supporters. In some instances, they may activate social identities that link to foreign affairs. The BJP's linking of Hindu nationalism to counterterrorism policies and heightened tensions with Pakistan is one such example of this. In the United States, issues like trade, aid, and immigration for which attitudes are correlated both with partisan identity and other forms of social identity are more likely to be susceptible to this dynamic.

In theory, nonpartisan institutions should help to stabilize foreign policy, in much the same way that independent central banks stabilize macroeconomic policy in democracies. These institutions should operate outside the realm of party politics, fostering continuity in policy across successive administrations. In environments of extreme polarization, however, these nonpartisan institutions are not immune to politicization. In fact, they may be especially attractive targets for enterprising politicians.

The weakening of vertical and horizontal constraints on executive power means that, in the long run, we should observe greater divergence in foreign policy preferences in extremely polarized democracies. These patterns should contribute to more changes in foreign affairs across successive executives. To be clear, policy change is itself not a bad thing. However, the volatility in foreign policymaking that originates from partisan politics can be problematic in multiple respects. In *Volatile States in International Politics*, political scientist Eleonora Mattiacci explains how volatility—the combination of change and inconsistency—is shaped by various domestic groups competing for

TABLE 2.1. Polarization and the erosion of democratic stability

	Ideal-type democracy	Highly polarized democracy
Vertical constraints	The public is more likely to reward politicians for taking foreign policy positions consistent with the median voter and enacting policies that provide public goods. Domestic partisan conflict is less likely to extend into foreign affairs.	The public is more likely to reward co-partisan politicians for taking ideologically extreme positions and reversing policies of an opposing party. Domestic partisan conflict is more likely to extend into foreign affairs.
Horizontal constraints	Politicians are more likely to maintain a tacit “partisan truce” in foreign policy. They are more likely to cooperate with opposing parties, pursue moderate foreign policies, and invest in institutions that maintain continuity in foreign affairs.	Politicians are less likely to maintain a tacit “partisan truce” in foreign policy. They are more likely to take extreme positions on foreign policy issues and to politicize the foreign policy bureaucracy for partisan gain.
Implication for democratic advantage	Democracies are more likely to display stability in their foreign policymaking over time.	Democracies are less likely to display stability in their foreign policymaking over time.

influence in foreign affairs.⁷¹ Mattiacci argues that volatility contributes to fear and crisis escalation in international politics. Volatility also undermines trust between allies and creates a broader sense of uncertainty about the direction of a country’s foreign policy.

Table 2.1 outlines how polarization erodes the ability of democracies to maintain relatively stable foreign policies, which is explored in chapter 4. The

71. Mattiacci 2023.

first column of the table explains how systems of constraint, and the corresponding democratic advantages, function in an ideal-type liberal democracy with low to moderate levels of polarization, which is the relevant counterfactual or point of comparison for this study. The second column shows what happens in an extremely polarized country, with high levels of both affective and ideological polarization.

Stability Hypothesis 3: As polarization becomes more extreme, democracies are less likely to display stability in their foreign policymaking over time.

2.4 The Credibility Advantage

In 1898, British troops marched up the Nile River toward an Egyptian village called Fashoda. Their aim was to build a railway through the African continent. When the British arrived, however, they encountered quite a surprise: a French military force beat them to Fashoda. The small village became the unexpected site of an international diplomatic crisis. The French force demanded concessions in order to leave the area, while the British refused to concede.

Back in England, the prime minister Lord Salisbury emphasized the hard line the British would take in negotiations with the French. He released details about the incident to the public, stressing Britain's resolute position. In doing so, Lord Salisbury effectively tied his hands: he could not order British troops to back down without risking public outrage. After details of the incident were released, the main opposition party in the British Parliament, the Liberal Party, came out in support of the prime minister's position on the Fashoda Crisis. Since the Liberal Party had no incentive to collude with the prime minister, its support of Lord Salisbury's position was credible. It became clear to the French that the British did not intend to compromise. Not willing to risk a full-fledged war, the French army withdrew its troops from Fashoda, effectively ending the crisis.⁷²

Political scientist Kenneth Schultz drew attention to the Fashoda Crisis as a crucial example of how effective democracies can be in communicating their resolve in international politics.⁷³ Schultz's research emphasizes a second advantage democracies have relative to nondemocracies: a credibility

72. Schultz 2001b.

73. Schultz 2001b.

advantage in signaling information to their adversaries in international relations. In general, when countries negotiate over issues in international politics, they have incentives to misrepresent their position in order to gain a more favorable deal.⁷⁴ Leaders may bluff by saying they are unwilling to compromise on their stance when in fact compromise is possible. These incentives make it challenging to credibly communicate information to foreign counterparts. Democracies, however, have institutional features that make it hard for democratic leaders to bluff, which makes their word more credible relative to autocrats.⁷⁵

There are many uses of the term “credibility” in international relations. Here, I am interested in credibility of signals sent to other actors—especially foreign adversaries—in international politics. These signals come in the form of threats or promises directed at other countries. There are also a lot of implications of the credibility advantage.⁷⁶ This book focuses on two implications. First, democracies are better able to issue credible threats and signal their resolve to their adversaries in the context of an international crisis. Second, democracies are better able to credibly express their positions in international negotiations, giving them greater leverage in the negotiation process.

A first implication of the credibility advantage is that democracies are better able to issue credible threats because systems of vertical and horizontal constraints make them accountable to domestic actors. Vertical constraints make leaders accountable to the public. The logic of *audience costs* assumes that leaders are punished by their publics for not following through on their word.⁷⁷ When a democratic leader escalates a dispute and then backs down, we anticipate they will be penalized electorally.⁷⁸ The anticipation of audience costs prevents democratic leaders from bluffing, or issuing threats that they do not intend to follow through. As a result, the threats that are issued by democracies should in theory be more credible.

74. Fearon 1995.

75. Fearon 1994; Schultz 2001a.

76. For example, an implication of the credibility advantage that is not a focus of this book is that it allows democracies to resolve disputes peacefully with one another. Institutional features that make democracies more transparent and credible can mitigate information problems that contribute to the onset of war. See, e.g., Schultz 1999, 2001a.

77. Fearon 1994; Smith 1998.

78. Kertzer and Brutger 2016; Levendusky and Horowitz 2012; Levy et al. 2015; Tomz 2007.

But democratic leaders have additional tools to enhance the credibility of their threats. One thing they can do is to leverage the agreement of domestic actors like the public and the political opposition. Because democratic leaders are vertically constrained, foreign observers know that leaders care about public opinion on important foreign policy decisions. During times of crisis, strong public rallies around decision-makers are visible to foreign adversaries. Leaders can wield public displays of support to deter potential challengers or signal resolve.

Democratic leaders can also leverage horizontal constraints to increase the credibility of their threats. A key insight from Kenneth Schultz is that the political opposition gives democracies an informational advantage relative to autocracies in crisis bargaining.⁷⁹ In *Democracy and Coercive Diplomacy*, Schultz argues that domestic political opponents prevent democratic leaders from issuing threats they do not plan to carry out. Leaders fear that empty threats will have political repercussions.⁸⁰ As a result, democracies are more selective about the threats they make, which increases the credibility of the threats we observe. Schultz emphasizes that, when the political opposition agrees with a leader's crisis decision-making, this is a particularly credible signal. In Schultz's analysis of the Fashoda Crisis, the British appeared resolved to the French because the opposition party (the Liberal Party) supported Lord Salisbury's position.⁸¹ This example suggests that democratic leaders can leverage agreement between the executive and the opposition to enhance the credibility of their threats in a crisis.

Interestingly, in other contexts, democratic leaders may also be able to leverage *disagreement* between domestic actors to improve policy outcomes. This relates to a second implication of the credibility advantage: domestic constraints can improve the negotiating position of democracies when they bargain with other countries. Economist Thomas Schelling articulates this intuition, referred to as the "Schelling conjecture,"⁸² with application to U.S. foreign policy in his book *The Strategy of Conflict*: "If the executive branch is free to negotiate the best arrangement it can, it may be unable to make any position stick and may end by conceding controversial points. . . . But, if the executive branch negotiates under legislative authority, with its position

79. Schultz 1998, 1999, 2001a.

80. Schultz 2001a.

81. Schultz 2001b.

82. Milner 1997.

constrained by the law . . . then the executive branch has a firm position that is visible to its negotiating partners.”⁸³

Political scientist Robert Putnam formalized this logic by describing an international negotiation as a “two-level game.”⁸⁴ At the first level, negotiators from different countries bargain with one another to construct an agreement. At the second level, domestic actors within each country choose whether or not to adopt the agreement. Putnam argues that the size of a country’s domestic *win-set*—the set of international agreements that would be ratified by domestic actors—depends on its political institutions. Since democracies have more domestic constraints, they have a smaller win-set than autocracies. When negotiating with a foreign counterpart, a democratic leader can point to the visible position of the public or the political opposition in order to obtain an international agreement closer to their preferred outcome. Since their hands are tied by domestic politics, democratic leaders can credibly say, “This deal would be unacceptable to the public” or “The opposition won’t agree to ratify this treaty.” Given that autocrats do not face similar constraints, they have less leverage than their democratic counterparts. Much subsequent work explores the conditions under which democracies negotiate more or less effectively based on the policy preferences of parties, legislatures, and other domestic actors.⁸⁵

To illustrate how this leverage works in practice, political scientists Howard Lehman and Jennifer McCoy detail negotiations of a 1988 agreement between the Brazilian government and its international creditors to restructure Brazil’s debt.⁸⁶ During the negotiations, Brazil was in the midst of a democratic transition. The combination of crippling debt and fledgling democratic institutions created huge challenges for Brazilian President José Sarney. As inflation skyrocketed, domestic pressure on President Sarney prompted him to declare a moratorium on interest payments to creditors. International banks retaliated with sanctions to pressure Brazil into restarting payments. But, over time, the Brazilian government was able to lift the moratorium and achieve an agreement that was relatively favorable to Brazil. How? Commercial banks recognized that it would not be politically feasible for President Sarney to accept

83. Schelling 1960, 28.

84. Putnam 1988.

85. Friedrichs 2022; Mayer 1992; Mo 1995; Milner and Rosendorff 1996, 1997; Milner 1999; Tarar 2001.

86. Lehman and McCoy 1992.

harsh austerity measures. In fact, Brazil's leverage came from the fact that the Sarney administration was so constrained domestically. Lehman and McCoy argue that, in this instance, Brazilian negotiators were able to "manipulat[e] the perception of domestic weakness and turmoil to their advantage in negotiations with creditors, especially in the context of a transition to democratic politics."⁸⁷ Had Brazil remained an autocracy, the researchers posit that the final agreement would have been much less favorable to Brazil.

These examples show that the constraints democratic leaders face at home can make the information they reveal in international politics more credible. Accountability to the public and the political opposition deters leaders from bluffing in international politics. Leaders are also able to leverage both support and dissent from domestic actors when they bargain with foreign adversaries. During international crises, when domestic actors set aside partisan politics and support the leader's decision-making, this provides a clear signal of resolve to adversaries. Democratic leaders can also leverage more moderate forms of domestic disagreement; they credibly indicate that their hands are tied by domestic politics when negotiating international agreements. In theory, the credibility advantage makes it easier for democracies to negotiate effectively and ensures the threats they issue will be taken seriously, making them more formidable adversaries overall.

2.4.1 Polarization and the Erosion of Democratic Credibility

Extreme polarization diminishes the credibility advantage by making it more difficult for democracies to signal information to adversaries. In highly polarized environments, a democratic leaders's credibility may be undermined because major internal disagreements within their country are also visible to foreign rivals. To understand how polarization jeopardizes democratic credibility, first consider how polarization interacts with vertical constraints. In a nonpolarized context, vertical constraints provide leaders with incentives to make decisions in foreign policy that appeal to broad sections of the electorate. Polarization itself does not necessarily weaken this electoral accountability. In fact, some degree of party cohesion is essential so that voters can hold parties accountable for policy outcomes. But, as polarization becomes more extreme, the nature of vertical constraints changes in important ways.

87. Lehman and McCoy 1992, 640.

For one, partisans in a highly polarized society become increasingly distrustful of an out-party leader and, by extension, their foreign policy decision-making. Successful foreign policy hinges on the assumption that a democratic leader acts in the best interest of the general public to maximize national welfare. A strong degree of trust in the executive is uniquely important in foreign affairs. Relative to domestic policy, in foreign policy, leaders have much more of an information advantage and more autonomy to execute decisions. For democratic leaders to be able to effectively leverage public support in an international crisis, the public must trust their leader's decision-making. But, in societies characterized both by ideological and affective polarization, a partisan public will be skeptical of the values and policies of a leader from an opposing party. Strong partisans will be especially likely to be biased in their evaluations of a leader's policy response, engaging in what is widely known as politically motivated reasoning.⁸⁸ This means that a more polarized public will be less likely to rally behind the leader and support their policy response in a time of crisis. As a consequence, leaders will struggle to leverage support from their domestic publics to signal resolve.

Since 2010, Israel has faced sharply increasing levels of political polarization, including on national security issues. One of the hallmarks of Israeli prime minister Benjamin Netanyahu's foreign policy is his hawkish stance toward Iran. While supporters of Netanyahu's conservative Likud Party tend to agree with the prime minister's characterization of the Iranian threat, some supporters of other parties question whether Netanyahu exaggerates the threat for political gain.⁸⁹ In 2022, Bloomberg News published an op-ed entitled, "Some Israelis Are More Scared of Netanyahu Than Iran," highlighting skepticism of Netanyahu's foreign policy among Israeli voters on the left.⁹⁰ If a new crisis were to arise between Iran and Israel, partisans who distrust Netanyahu's judgment may be unlikely to support his policy response.

In extremely polarized societies, the nature of electoral accountability also changes by more closely tying individual assessments of politicians to the

88. On politically motivated reasoning see, e.g., Guay and Johnston 2022; Kraft, Lodge, and Taber 2015; Leeper and Slothuus 2014; Lodge and Taber 2013. For examples of motivated reasoning in public opinion on foreign policy see, e.g., Gaines et al. 2007; Kertzer, Rathbun, and Rathbun 2020.

89. Leslie 2022.

90. Chafets 2022.

performance of their party. Politicians are rewarded for their party's wins and benefit from the other party's failures. This dynamic can be driven both by ideological and affective polarization. Where the public is more ideologically polarized on certain foreign policy issues, they are more committed to their preferred policies. As a consequence, they will be more favorable toward co-partisan politicians who try to prevent leaders from the opposite party from enacting their own policies. Likewise, where the public is more affectively polarized, they will be more likely to see losses for the opposing party as "wins" for their own party. As both ideological and affective polarization grow, the public will both be more likely to distrust leaders from the opposite party and reward members of their own party for obstructing those leaders.

Credibility Hypothesis 1A: As polarization becomes more extreme, the public is less likely to trust the foreign policy decision-making of leaders from an opposing party.

Credibility Hypothesis 1B: As polarization becomes more extreme, the public is more likely to reward co-partisan politicians for obstructing leaders from an opposing party.

These incentives have implications for horizontal constraints, or how the opposition party or coalition constrains the executive. In a highly polarized society, partisan competition increasingly becomes zero sum. Political wins become not only policy successes of one's own party, but also failures of the out-party. In foreign policy, this means that an executive's opponents reap benefits from strongly criticizing or obstructing the executive. A more polarized public gives the opposition party incentives to ensure that the executive is less successful in enacting its foreign policy agenda.

In the United States, this phenomenon is well documented by congressional scholars, who detail the institutional changes that have increased congressional polarization since the 1990s.⁹¹ In *Beyond Ideology*, for example, political scientist Frances Lee provides evidence for teamism dynamics in the Senate, including in foreign affairs.⁹² She shows that contemporary patterns of Senate polarization cannot merely be explained by growing ideological differences between Republicans and Democrats. In an analysis of congressional roll-call votes, Lee distinguishes between votes with ideological

91. Cox and McCubbins 1993, 2005; Lee 2009; Theriault 2008.

92. Lee 2009.

content and procedural votes with nonideological content. She demonstrates that while votes related to ideological issues have become more polarized, there has also been remarkable party cohesion on nonideological issues. This teamsmanship dynamic is reinforced by institutions within Congress and by an affectively polarized public.⁹³

Affective polarization and teamsmanship dynamics are neither specific to the United States nor to the current historical moment. Chapter 1, for instance, discussed one of the more extreme historical cases of polarization in 1930s France. During the 1936 election, which resulted in the election of the first socialist prime minister, Léon Blum, a slogan adopted by right-wing French leaders—“Better Hitler Than Blum”—implied that foreign occupation by Nazi Germany might be preferable to left-wing leadership in France.⁹⁴ As foreign policy polarizes, political parties may have fundamentally different relationships with foreign adversaries. In the most extreme cases, like in 1930s France, a deeply polarized society could lead politicians to be more favorable toward a foreign adversary than a domestic political opponent. In practice, of course, such cases are very rare. Instead, we might expect that a polarized environment leads politicians to focus on preventing “wins” from the other side. This could include attempts to obstruct the other side through grandstanding and criticizing how a leader handles a crisis or a negotiation with a foreign adversary.

Credibility Hypothesis 2A: As polarization becomes more extreme, politicians are less likely to defer to a leader from an opposing party in times of crisis.

Credibility Hypothesis 2B: As polarization becomes more extreme, politicians are more likely to consistently oppose or actively undermine leaders from an opposing party in foreign policy.

How does polarization affect the credibility advantage? In brief, it reshapes the strategic incentives of the political opposition in crisis bargaining and international negotiations. In ideal liberal democracies with more moderate levels of polarization, during a security crisis the position of the domestic opposition can be informative in democracies. A threat issued by the executive and backed by the opposition is highly credible.⁹⁵ During times of crisis, we

93. Abramowitz 2010; Abramowitz and Webster 2016; Iyengar, Sood, and Lelkes 2012; Mason 2015; Rogowski and Sutherland 2016; Iyengar et al. 2019.

94. Richards 2006.

95. Schultz 2001a.

expect opposition parties to recognize the gravity of the issue at stake and set partisan politics aside. This is why, traditionally, the opposition party supports or defers to the executive during national security crises.⁹⁶

However, in extremely polarized contexts, the opposition virtually always has incentives to disagree with the executive. In extreme cases, national security crises are not immune from this problem. The credibility advantage that comes from presenting a unified front to a foreign adversary is diminished. In practice, it becomes difficult for both the executive and the adversary to interpret disagreement by the opposition party. Does criticism from the opposition reflect sincere preferences or is it political posturing?⁹⁷ Is distrust of how an out-party executive is handling a crisis warranted or not? In a highly partisan environment, signals from the opposition that may be informative to an adversary in a nonpolarized context may be uninformative at best and could sow even greater confusion at worst.

Analysts are concerned, for example, about how political polarization in South Korea could impact its ability to be viewed as a credible adversary by North Korea. In the 2022 presidential election, the two primary parties in South Korea—the right-wing People Power Party and the left-wing Democratic Party—espoused very different positions on North Korea policy. The People Power Party favored a much more hawkish stance toward North Korea. In the election, the People Power Party’s candidate, Yoon Suk Yeol, narrowly defeated the presidential candidate from the incumbent Democratic Party. Commentators worried that, if a crisis were to arise on the Korean peninsula, leadership from the two parties would be unable to agree on an appropriate response. Heightened polarization could also diminish presidential accountability by eroding audience costs. Dong Joon Park argued, for example, that if President Yoon’s supporters were unlikely to hold him accountable for issuing empty threats, the threats he issued would be viewed as less credible by North Korean leader Kim Jong Un.⁹⁸ Park explained that such dynamics could exacerbate tensions on the Korean peninsula by increasing the likelihood that North Korean leadership would provoke South Korea to test the president’s resolve.

96. Brody 1991.

97. This logic parallels the insight from Kreps, Saunders, and Schultz (2018) that polarization can make it difficult to distinguish between partisan bias and hawkishness among legislators when ratifying arms control agreements.

98. Park 2022.

Extreme polarization also poses problems for international negotiations.⁹⁹ In principle, the fact that democratic leaders are constrained in international negotiations should work to their advantage: they can credibly say that an agreement will not be ratified without buy-in from the political opposition. This implies that, at low to moderate levels of polarization, democracies are advantaged when negotiating with nondemocratic adversaries. Yet, in highly polarized settings, the probability of any zone of agreement between the executive and the opposition becomes significantly less likely in the first place. Once again, this divergence may arise from ideological disagreements over the foreign policy issue at stake. But it can also arise from teamism dynamics or from electoral incentives rooted in an affectively polarized public.

Irrespective of how partisan divergence arises, at its extremes there are multiple possible implications for international negotiations. For one, if negotiations are ongoing, extreme polarization can increase the likelihood that they will collapse or that an agreement will fail to be ratified. A high degree of polarization can also prevent negotiations from occurring at all. Anticipating dissent from the political opposition, leaders may believe they do not have the political capital required to initiate a complex negotiation with a foreign adversary. In the United States, Republican President Donald Trump withdrew the United States from the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), an agreement addressing Iran's nuclear program, in 2018. Democratic presidential candidate Joe Biden pledged during his 2020 presidential campaign to rejoin the agreement. Once President Biden took office in 2021, however, renewed attempts to negotiate quickly faltered. The combination of shifting politics in Iran and the politicization of U.S.–Iranian relations in Washington complicated diplomatic negotiations. By July 2021, the *New York Times* reported that “whatever deal [the Biden administration] strikes will be a political problem in Washington.”¹⁰⁰ The following year, a White House spokesperson confirmed the deal had been all but abandoned, noting, “The JCPOA is not our focus right now. It’s not on the agenda.”¹⁰¹

This discussion highlights how extreme polarization can make it more difficult to respond to an adversary in a unified manner during a security crisis.

99. Although this book focuses on how polarization affects democracy's credibility while negotiating with an adversary, other researchers have identified additional ways that polarization impacts international negotiations (see, e.g., Friedrichs 2022).

100. Sanger, Jakes, and Fassihi 2021.

101. Ravid and Nichols 2022.

TABLE 2.2. Polarization and the erosion of democratic credibility

	Ideal-type liberal democracy	Extremely polarized democracy
Vertical constraint	The public is more likely to trust the foreign policy decision-making of their elected leaders. They are more likely to reward politicians for making decisions that lead to good foreign policy outcomes.	The public is less likely to trust the foreign policy decision-making of leaders from an opposing party. They are more likely to reward co-partisan politicians for obstructing leaders from an opposing party.
Horizontal constraint	Politicians are more likely to rally behind a leader during times of crisis. They are likely to oppose leaders only when there is principled disagreement over foreign policy.	Politicians are less likely to defer to a leader from an opposing party during times of crisis. They are more likely to consistently oppose or actively undermine leaders from an opposing party in foreign policy.
Implication for democratic advantage	Democracies are more likely to send credible signals to adversaries in international negotiations and crisis bargaining.	Democracies are less likely to send credible signals to adversaries in international negotiations and crisis bargaining.

It can also make it challenging to effectively leverage partisan disagreement during a complex negotiation with a foreign adversary. As table 2.2 shows, these processes can erode the credibility advantage democracies have in foreign affairs. The second column of table 2.2 summarizes the hypotheses that will be tested in chapter 5.

Credibility Hypothesis 3: As polarization becomes more extreme, democracies are less likely to send credible signals to adversaries in international negotiations and crisis bargaining.

2.5 The Reliability Advantage

On February 7, 1992, in the Dutch city of Maastricht, representatives from twelve European countries signed an agreement that laid the foundation for the EU. The Maastricht Treaty spurred the integration of economic and security policy in Europe, paving the way for a shared currency and free movement of European citizens across national borders. There was much fanfare on the signing day. As one media outlet reported, “There were hussars and a band to welcome the dignitaries, glorious spring flowers everywhere, the Limburg Symphony Orchestra playing Mozart and, of course, a champagne reception and banquet.”¹⁰²

Despite the celebratory mood, the signatures themselves did not fully commit the countries to an agreement. Each country would need to ratify the agreement through a separate process. Some countries, like Ireland, France, and Denmark, chose to put the treaty to a public vote through a national referendum. Other countries, like Italy, Greece, and the Netherlands, opted for a ratification process that required the support of a large majority of legislators in their respective parliaments. After a lengthy ratification process spanning twelve countries, the treaty entered into force on November 1, 1993, nearly twenty-one months after the signing date.¹⁰³

Throughout the 1990s, there were persistent fears that countries would renege on the agreement. But, successive rounds of enlargement through the mid-2000s strengthened the EU. One explanation for the resilience of the agreement was the arduous process for entering it. These ratification processes required some degree of buy-in from the public, an opposition party, or both. Precisely because many domestic stakeholders were involved in the ratification process, the agreement was more firmly entrenched.

Ratification of the Maastricht Treaty and similar major international agreements reflect a third advantage democracies have in international affairs: a reliability advantage. Relative to nondemocracies, democracies are better able to commit to, and comply with, international agreements. This makes democracies more cooperative in international politics.¹⁰⁴ Democracies tend

102. Wolf 1992.

103. Abbey and Bromfield 1994.

104. International cooperation occurs when “actors adjust their behavior to the actual or anticipated preferences of others, through a process of policy coordination” (Keohane 1984, 51–52).

to be more reliable partners because they sacrifice short-term interests for long-term policy successes.¹⁰⁵

Like the other two advantages, the reliability advantage is shaped by vertical and horizontal constraints. Vertical constraints make it more likely that leaders follow agreed-upon procedures and adhere to standards of acceptable behavior, or *norms*, when entering into and exiting from international agreements. Two sets of preferences internalized by liberal publics in theory reinforce the reliability advantage.

The first expectation is that, all else equal, democratic publics will prefer that their leaders follow established policymaking procedures domestically when they enter into, or exit from, international agreements. Democratic governments share an understanding with the public about the process by which their country can make commitments to foreign nations. Some aspects of this process may be formalized. International agreements may be subject to public referenda or ratification by a legislature. Other aspects of this process could include informal norms or unwritten rules. Leaders could be expected, for example, to educate the public or consult with members of the opposition before entering into a major international agreement.

If democratic publics internalize these norms, they should be averse to their leaders acting unilaterally or on their own without the support of the public or opposition parties. Observational and experimental work shows that democratic publics in fact care about some of these process concerns. For example, the public responds negatively when leaders act unilaterally without the consent of the public,¹⁰⁶ are not transparent in the process of negotiating international agreements,¹⁰⁷ or deliberately lie or mislead the public about foreign affairs.¹⁰⁸ Effective vertical constraints should provide incentives for leaders to follow norms of acceptable behavior in the foreign policymaking process.

The second expectation is that democratic publics prefer that their leaders do not renege on existing commitments made to allies. There are multiple reasons why publics could hold these preferences. One potential reason is

105. Note that the reliability advantage is related to the stability advantage in that they both imply consistency across time. However, reliability also implies sustained partnership, cooperation, or adherence to international law across time.

106. Reeves and Rogowski 2018.

107. Myrick 2024.

108. Maxey 2021; Yarhi-Milo and Ribar 2023.

normative: democratic publics may internalize liberal norms of cooperation, peaceful dispute resolution, and adherence to the rule of law.¹⁰⁹ For these citizens, abandoning international commitments is not appropriate behavior for a democratic ally. Another potential reason is self-interest: democratic publics dislike it when leaders violate international commitments because these violations damage their country's reputation in foreign affairs.¹¹⁰ For these citizens, the concern is that abandoning commitments has reputational costs. Public opinion research supports these arguments by showing that, in general, democratic citizens tend to be averse to their leaders reneging on existing international commitments, especially security commitments made to allies and partners.¹¹¹

While vertical constraints give democratic leaders incentives to not violate their commitments, horizontal constraints contribute to the reliability advantage by making it challenging to do so in practice. Often, entry into, or withdrawal from, an international agreement requires some degree of support from other domestic political stakeholders. In *Democratic Commitments*, political scientist Lisa Martin argues that intragovernmental constraints on the executive from legislatures create durable forms of international cooperation.¹¹² When legislatures anticipate conflict with the executive over foreign policy, they find ways to institutionalize their participation in international agreements. In the long run, institutionalized legislative participation in foreign affairs makes democracies more reliable. The involvement of national European parliaments in the creation of the EU's internal market was, according to Martin, critical for a more durable form of regional integration.

In the case of the Maastricht Treaty and the related agreements that followed, both vertical and horizontal constraints reinforced commitments to the EU. If a leader of one of its member countries opted to unilaterally withdraw from the EU, it is likely they would face domestic backlash. Countries that choose to exit the EU do so only with the explicit consent of domestic stakeholders. In the 2015 Brexit vote, for example, the majority of voters in a national referendum voted for the UK to leave the EU.

The reliability advantage is evident across multiple foreign policy domains. International relations scholars primarily emphasize the reliability of security

109. Katzenstein 1996; Risse-Kappen 1997; Adler and Barnett 1998.

110. Leeds 1999; McGillivray and Smith 2000.

111. Tomz 2008; Tomz and Weeks 2021.

112. Martin 2000.

commitments, often in the form of military alliances. *Alliances* are formal international agreements related to security cooperation. Alliance partners, for example, may pledge to come to each other's aid in the event that their security is threatened. Democracies are perceived as more reliable because they are less likely to renege on their alliance commitments. Political scientists demonstrate that alliances between democracies are less likely to fail relative to alliances that include nondemocratic countries.¹¹³ Democratic alliances are durable even in the face of leadership turnover. Political scientists Ashley Leeds, Michaela Mattes, and Jeremy Vogel show that, while there is no correlation between leadership turnover and alliance violations, a change in the leader's supporting societal coalition increases the likelihood of a violation. However, this effect is driven by autocratic rather than democratic countries. The researchers conclude that democratic institutions provide stability even when there are major changes in a country's leadership.¹¹⁴

Beyond alliances and security cooperation, the reliability advantage impacts international economic outcomes and adherence to international law. A substantial literature illustrates that democratic countries better attract foreign direct investment from multinational corporations than do autocracies.¹¹⁵ Constraints on democratic leaders make the expropriation of foreign investment less likely and reduce the amount of political risk foreign firms face when investing abroad.¹¹⁶ Democratic countries are also advantaged with superior access to international credit and higher sovereign bond ratings given that they are seen as less likely to renege on their commitments by defaulting.¹¹⁷

Strong domestic commitment to the rule of law is a central reason why democracies tend to also adhere to international law.¹¹⁸ Democratic countries are more likely to follow rules constructed by the international monetary system,¹¹⁹ engage in trade cooperation,¹²⁰ resolve trade disputes within existing

113. Gaubatz 1996; Reed 1997; Leeds and Savun 2007.

114. Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel 2009.

115. Jensen 2003, 2008; Li 2009; Pandya 2014.

116. Jensen 2003, 2008.

117. Beaulieu, Cox, and Saiegh 2012; Schultz and Weingast 2003.

118. As Simmons (2000, 822) summarizes, "Governments that have invested in and rest on a stable legal framework at home are unlikely to jeopardize this reputation by lightly flouting international legal obligations."

119. Simmons 2000.

120. Mansfield, Milner, and Rosendorff 2002.

legal frameworks,¹²¹ and comply with human rights treaties they ratify.¹²² While democracies may be more selective about the agreements they enter, they are less likely than nondemocracies to renege on their commitments made to other countries. Likewise, democracies tend to cooperate with other states, pursue multilateral solutions, and comply with international agreements, making them more reliable partners.

2.5.1 *Polarization and the Erosion of Democratic Reliability*

How does polarization impact the reliability advantage? In nonpolarized environments, vertical constraints reinforce the reliability of democratic commitments. We assume that democratic leaders will be held accountable by the public for entering into international agreements unilaterally or for reneging on those commitments once they are made. These vertical constraints could arise from internalized commitments to democratic governance and rule of law. But they could also arise from self-interested publics who are simply concerned about the reputational costs of abandoning existing agreements.

I argue that, in an extremely polarized environment, the nature of this electoral accountability changes. As a function of diverging ideological preferences or increasing affective polarization, a partisan public cares more about their party's ability to implement its policies. As a consequence, they are less likely to object when co-partisan leaders violate democratic procedures or renege on existing agreements. This impacts both entry into, and withdrawal from, international agreements, in turn affecting the reliability of democratic commitments.

In terms of entering international agreements, in a polarized environment vertical constraints are insufficient to ensure that democratic leaders abide by norms of the foreign policymaking process. A partisan public highly values a co-partisan incumbent enacting their preferred policy. This gives leaders more incentives to act unilaterally in foreign affairs to secure political wins and accomplish policy objectives favored by their supporters.

In 2016, for example, Democratic President Barack Obama entered the United States into the Paris Agreement on climate, a multilateral agreement negotiated at the 2015 UN Climate Change Conference. The Paris Agreement aimed to mitigate global temperature increases by reducing greenhouse

121. Davis and Bermeo 2009; Kim 2008.

122. Hathaway 2007.

gas emissions. Unlike the Kyoto Protocol, a climate agreement that President Bill Clinton signed in 1998 but was never ratified by the U.S. Senate, the Obama administration adopted the Paris Agreement as a nonbinding political commitment. This was widely seen as an effort to bypass the Senate ratification process given high levels of congressional polarization and the difficulty of passing international treaties.¹²³ U.S. entry into the agreement was overwhelmingly supported by Democratic voters; public opinion polls estimate that 86 percent of self-identified Democrats supported the Paris Agreement.¹²⁴ Congressional Republicans raised objections to what they described as executive overreach, emphasizing that major international agreements like the Paris Agreement should be subject to Senate ratification. Republican Senator Jim Inhofe from Oklahoma released a statement condemning the climate agreement and noting that “Americans do not support it when their president sidesteps Congress.”¹²⁵ However, because of the popularity of the Paris Agreement among Obama’s core supporters and the perceived impossibility of generating the bipartisan support necessary to ratify the agreement, the Obama administration had incentives to make the international commitment unilaterally.

In terms of exiting international agreements, in highly polarized environments vertical constraints also become less likely to reinforce cooperation between countries if domestic interests conflict with international agreements. As polarization increases, voters put more weight on seeing their own team win or their preferred policy enacted relative both to normative commitments to multilateral cooperation and to concerns about the reputational costs associated with reneging on existing commitments. This intuition is consistent with public opinion research on international commitments. Political scientist Stephen Chaudoin, for example, shows that members of the public who have strong prior opinions about trade are less likely to punish leaders for reneging on their promises by breaking an international trade agreement.¹²⁶ Chaudoin’s findings suggest that individuals who have strong policy preferences are more willing to overlook violations of international commitments,

123. As one scholar of international law wrote, “Obama joined the United States to the Paris Agreement without seeking specific legislative approval . . . precisely because such approval would not have been forthcoming” (Galbraith 2017, 1681).

124. Marlon, Fine, and Leiserowitz 2016.

125. Inhofe 2016.

126. Chaudoin 2014.

especially when those violations result in outcomes consistent with their own preferences. Setting aside policy preferences, in extremely polarized settings, strong partisans may even be willing to overlook more blatant violations of international law simply because they result in a “win” for their own party.

Returning to the example of the Paris Agreement, in 2017, when Republican President Donald Trump announced that he would withdraw the United States from the agreement, Democratic legislators raised many objections. One objection was that reneging on this commitment would undermine U.S. credibility and global standing. However, Trump believed that his core supporters, who were skeptical both of multilateralism and of environmental movements, would reward him for reneging on the deal. The *New York Times* ran an article entitled “In Rejecting Popular Paris Accord, Trump Bets on His Base” that explained, “[I]n Mr. Trump’s calculation, withdrawing from the accord will be a political winner.”¹²⁷ From the perspective of the Trump administration, these considerations outweighed the reputational costs the United States might incur by reneging on the agreement. Such examples illustrate that, in polarized societies, where ideological beliefs, partisan loyalties, or both drive divergence in policy preferences, a partisan public is less likely to constrain a leader’s actions when they undermine existing international commitments.

Reliability Hypothesis 1: As polarization becomes more extreme, the public is less likely to punish co-partisan leaders who act unilaterally when making foreign policy or who renege on international commitments.

The reliability advantage is also undermined by how extreme polarization interacts with systems of horizontal constraint. In a polarized environment, it is difficult to reach the cross-party consensus needed to pass major foreign policy legislation. In the UK, a polarizing Brexit debate meant that Conservative prime minister Theresa May was unable to garner enough cross-party support for a “soft” Brexit agreement in 2017, which would have left the UK more tightly tied to the EU. Failure to compromise, coupled with the strength and ideological commitments of the Euroskeptic wing of the Conservative Party, led to the election of Boris Johnson in July 2019 and the subsequent passage of a “hard” Brexit agreement that severed UK–EU ties.¹²⁸

127. Baker 2017.

128. Quinn, Allen, and Bartle 2024.

In presidential systems like the United States, an increase in polarization creates legislative gridlock that makes governing challenging. As political scientist Sarah Binder summarizes, “When ideological and electoral incentives propel the parties to the wings, abandoning the political center, lawmakers struggle to find broadly palatable solutions to the range of problems they face.”¹²⁹ Gridlock creates incentives for the president to bypass the legislature entirely when making foreign policy. These incentives exist in other areas of policymaking. However, they are especially pronounced in foreign affairs, where the president has an informational advantage over the legislature.¹³⁰ If the president takes this approach, legislators will find it difficult to check presidential power. Checks on executive power are most effective when they come from a bipartisan group of legislators. Yet, in a polarized environment, in-party legislators have little incentive to stop the president from enacting their preferred policy. Electoral accountability will also be unlikely to prevent the executive from acting unilaterally since high levels of polarization make the public less able to effectively constrain the executive.

One observable implication of this logic in American politics is that polarization makes the passage of international treaties—which must be ratified by a two-thirds vote in the U.S. Senate—especially difficult.¹³¹ In a gridlocked U.S. Senate, this level of bipartisan consensus is hard to attain. During polarized times, we should expect to see the executive using alternative ways to enter into international agreements. This includes more expansive use of executive agreements and nonbinding political commitments, neither of which require Senate ratification. U.S. entry into the Paris Agreement is one such example. While these types of international commitments are easier to make, they are also easier for subsequent leaders to exit, making them less durable than international agreements ratified by a legislature.

Reliability Hypothesis 2: As polarization becomes more extreme, politicians are more likely to bypass horizontal constraints in committing to international agreements, leading to less durable commitments.

If polarized democracies are less likely to enter into durable commitments, this has important, second-order reputational effects. Allies may be worried that polarized democracies will renege on promises made by

129. Binder 2014, 14.

130. Wildavsky 1966; Canes-Wrone, Howell, and Lewis 2008.

131. Schultz 2018; Peake 2017, 2022.

previous administrations. Countries may also be reluctant to initiate new agreements with highly polarized democracies, given doubts about the credibility of their commitments and uncertainty over the future of their foreign policy.

Global responses to the foreign policy of Brazilian President Jair Bolsonaro, who served in office from 2019 to 2022, illustrate this point. Throughout his 2018 campaign and subsequent presidential administration, Bolsonaro championed socially and fiscally conservative policies. But Bolsonaro's presidency also extended ideological and partisan conflict into foreign affairs. The president espoused strong anti-globalist and anti-communist sentiments, reimagining Brazil's partnerships with other nations. While in office, Bolsonaro strengthened Brazil's relationship with Israel under Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and the United States under President Donald Trump while taking a more hostile approach to relations with Venezuela and China. Rejecting principles of multilateralism, Bolsonaro threatened to withdraw from inter-governmental organizations like the UN and international agreements like the Paris Agreement.¹³²

While Bolsonaro ultimately did not follow through on his more extreme campaign promises in foreign affairs, his foreign policy positions created a great deal of uncertainty for the future. In a series of interviews with foreign policy experts, Brazilian scholar and journalist David Buarque recounts one expert as remarking that "people are confused about what to expect from the new leadership, and whether Brazil is a country that still can be considered a potential partner."¹³³ Worries about the long-term relationship between Brazil and its allies in the face of leader turnover reflect concerns about how highly polarized democracies face more uncertainty in the future and therefore are likely to be perceived as less reliable allies.

Table 2.3 outlines the relationship between polarization and the reliability advantage. Again, these hypotheses contrast how we expect vertical and horizontal constraints to function in an ideal-type liberal democracy versus in an extremely polarized democracy. The hypotheses in this table, and their implications for the reliability advantage, are explored in chapter 6.

Reliability Hypothesis 3: As polarization becomes more extreme, democracies are more likely to renege on international commitments and less likely to be perceived as reliable allies.

132. Buarque 2022.

133. Buarque 2022, 2458.

TABLE 2.3. Polarization and the erosion of democratic reliability

	Ideal-type liberal democracy	Extremely polarized democracy
Vertical constraint	The public reinforces democratic norms and procedures around entering into, and exiting from, international agreements. They are more likely to punish leaders who act unilaterally when making foreign policy or who are uncooperative in international politics.	The public is less likely to reinforce democratic norms and procedures around entering into, and exiting from, international agreements. They are less likely to punish co-partisan leaders who act unilaterally when making foreign policy or who renege on international commitments.
Horizontal constraint	Politicians seek cross-party support for major foreign policy legislation. Leaders secure buy-in from the political opposition to commit to international agreements, increasing the durability of these agreements.	Politicians struggle to build cross-party support for legislation. Leaders are more likely to bypass horizontal constraints in committing to international agreements, leading to less durable agreements.
Implication for democratic advantage	Democracies are less likely to renege on international commitments and more likely to be perceived as reliable allies.	Democracies are more likely to renege on international commitments and less likely to be perceived as reliable allies.

2.6 Interrelation of the Democratic Advantages

It is important to emphasize that the three democratic advantages discussed in this chapter are interrelated. As will be evident throughout this book, there are many cases in which growing polarization in foreign policy negatively impacts more than one of the three advantages. Moreover, if extreme

polarization erodes one democratic advantage, this could affect the others. If a highly polarized democracy frequently changes its foreign policy when a new party comes to power (affecting the stability advantage), its allies are likely to express doubts about the country's ability to maintain its commitments in the future (affecting the reliability advantage). While the stability and reliability advantage share some similarities, they are conceptually distinct. It is possible for a country to frequently change its policy positions without reneging on its international commitments. For example, under the two successive presidential administrations of Republican President Donald Trump (2017–2021) and Democratic President Joe Biden (2021–2025), the United States experienced dramatic swings in immigration and refugee policy that reflected the politicization of these issues. However, these policy changes did not impact the ability of the United States to maintain its security commitments to its foreign allies.

Likewise, credibility and reliability are also related. Both involve understanding how a country is perceived by other actors in the international system. For the purposes of this book, two distinctions between credibility and reliability are worth reemphasizing. The first relates to the relevant counterpart. In the examples used in this book, I refer to the credibility of signals in the context of bargaining with a foreign adversary. Such bargaining could occur during a crisis scenario or in a noncrisis scenario, such as while negotiating an international agreement. By contrast, I refer to the reliability of commitments made to foreign allies and partners. Chapters 5 and 6 will speak to how extreme polarization affects the ability of a democratic country to be a credible adversary and a reliable ally, respectively. The second distinction between credibility and reliability relates to time horizons. In the applications used in this book, credibility typically involves a judgment at a given moment in time (e.g., “Is the threat this country issued today credible?”), whereas reliability involves perceptions of a country's behavior at a future point in time (e.g., “Will the commitment that this country made be upheld in the future?”). Again, while these two judgments are related in practice, they are distinct in theory.

2.7 Conclusion

This chapter outlined three advantages democracies have in international politics relative to non-democracies. These advantages arise from systems of vertical constraint (accountability to an electorate) and horizontal constraint

(accountability to other institutions within government). It then explained how extreme polarization could undermine each advantage by eroding these systems of constraint and their ability to effectively check political power.

A first, overarching advantage democracies have in foreign affairs is a stability advantage. Despite regular leadership turnover, accountability to a large electorate and the median voter within it moderates foreign policy and prevents dramatic swings when a new leader comes to power. Parties have incentives to invest in nonpartisan institutions that maintain continuity in foreign policy across administrations. However, extreme polarization can make politicians less responsive to a median voter. As the public polarizes, officials may cater their policies toward ideologically extreme core supporters, and work to undo policies of the opposite party. And as the stakes of winning heighten in a polarized atmosphere, parties have fewer incentives to maintain a tacit partisan truce in foreign affairs. As a consequence, highly polarized democracies are likely to be associated with more foreign policy volatility.

The second democratic advantage is a credibility advantage. Democracies are better able to credibly signal information than autocracies can. Democratic leaders can use domestic constraints in various ways to their advantage when bargaining with foreign adversaries. Leaders can leverage agreement between domestic actors to credibly signal resolve in an international crisis. They can also leverage moderate disagreement between domestic actors to extract concessions during an international negotiation. However, growing affective polarization in the public and teamism dynamics give the political opposition incentives to obstruct leaders from the opposing party. As a result, it is difficult for polarized democracies to capitalize on the signaling advantages that arise from either bipartisan agreement or more moderate forms of partisan disagreement. The net effect is that highly polarized countries are less likely to send credible signals to their foreign adversaries.

The third democratic advantage is a reliability advantage. Democracies are more reliable because they are better able to commit to, and comply with, agreements made with international partners than are nondemocracies. However, polarization jeopardizes this advantage by giving democratic leaders incentives to bypass horizontal constraints when making agreements, which are easier to undo when a new party comes to power. A polarized public will be less able to hold their leader accountable for renegeing on commitments made to allies and partners.

The next four chapters develop evidence for the argument that extreme polarization can undermine democratic advantages in foreign policy. Chapter

3 draws on cross-national data to show associations between extreme polarization and troubling foreign policy outcomes. The remaining empirical chapters (chapters 4, 5, and 6) test the hypotheses in the contemporary American political context, demonstrating how polarization could negatively impact the ability of the United States to maintain stable foreign policy, and to be both a credible adversary and a reliable ally.

3

Cross-National Trends in Polarization and Foreign Policy

IN JANUARY 2016, Tsai Ing-wen secured the presidency of Taiwan in a victory for the Democratic Progressive Party (DPP). Tsai's election was significant for multiple reasons. She was the first female president of Taiwan, and only the second from the DPP, which had not held the presidency since 2008. Tsai's victory sparked debate about how the new president would reshape Taiwan's foreign policy and its relations with mainland China.¹ Tsai and other DPP leaders openly rejected the "one country, two systems" approach pursued by Chinese President Xi Jinping, marking a shift in cross-strait relations between China and Taiwan.²

During Tsai's administration, Taiwan faced increasing levels of domestic polarization. Polarization in Taiwanese politics is somewhat puzzling.³ Taiwan has a majoritarian system dominated by two major parties: the Kuomintang (KMT, or the "blues") and the DPP (or the "greens"). In such systems, political scientists expect policy preferences to converge as the major parties compete for the median voter in the electorate. However, throughout the 2010s and into the 2020s, Taiwan grappled with heightened polarization, characterized both by divergence between the parties as well as factionalism within each party.

The DPP and the KMT grew especially far apart on issues related to national identity and questions about Taiwanese relations with the United States and China. Partisan debates around the possibility of unification with mainland China intensified. Voters who identified with the DPP were far less supportive

1. Wu 2016.

2. Lee 2019.

3. Clark and Tan 2012.

of unification than those who identified with the KMT.⁴ The rhetoric and policies of Tsai Ing-wen's administration reflected this difference. President Tsai also reformed other aspects of Taiwan's foreign and defense policies. She established closer ties with the United States and the EU and presided over large increases in military spending in an effort to secure Taiwan's defense.⁵ During the 2024 Taiwanese election, major questions about Taiwanese foreign policy and relations with Beijing were again at the heart of the presidential race. DPP candidate Lai Ching-te—labeled “Beijing’s least favorite candidate”⁶—emerged victorious from the three-way contest with over 40 percent of the vote. The election left little doubt that electoral outcomes in Taiwan continue to be highly consequential for China–Taiwan relations.

Partisan politics in Taiwan appears to complicate its foreign policy. Were a crisis with mainland China to arise, domestic divisions in Taiwan could hamper a unified response. Polarization could also make it hard for Taiwan to establish a coherent and consistent China policy. As Richard Bush of the Brookings Institution writes, “Meeting the China challenge is made all the more difficult because decisions must be processed through Taiwan’s democratic system. . . . Yet divisions between and within camps constrain any effort to forge a coherent policy.”⁷ In the future, we may also expect foreign and defense policies to differ substantially under DPP versus KMT presidential administrations.

The Taiwan case demonstrates that polarization creates challenges for democratic foreign policymaking. Chapter 2 argued that democracies tend to have advantages in making foreign policy relative to nondemocracies. However, as polarization becomes more extreme, democratic advantages are steadily eroded. In highly polarized times, a democracy is much less likely to be a credible adversary and a reliable ally. A polarized democracy’s policies will be more likely to fluctuate with leader and party turnover, creating volatility in foreign affairs.

To begin exploring these patterns, this chapter draws on descriptive evidence about trends in cross-national polarization and foreign policy using new data on ideological positions of executive and opposition parties and coalitions in democracies. I identify contexts that display extreme levels

4. Wang 2019.

5. Shepherd and Chen 2022.

6. Atlantic Council 2024.

7. Bush 2021.

of ideological polarization on a right–left spectrum and extreme levels of polarization in foreign affairs on a hawk–dove spectrum. I then incorporate these measures of polarization into existing, well-known models of democratic advantages in international relations. First, analyses of the stability advantage consider how extreme polarization correlates with changes in foreign policy positions based on roll-call voting at UNGA. Second, analyses of the credibility advantage look at the relationship between extreme polarization and the credibility of threats issued in interstate disputes. Third, analyses of the reliability advantage probe the association between extreme polarization and the ability of democracies to maintain alliance commitments.

Collectively, these analyses show support for the overarching democratic advantages: relative to nondemocracies, democracies appear to be more stable, credible, and reliable in foreign affairs. However, the findings also suggest considerable variation among democracies that arises from different levels of polarization. Democracies experiencing extreme polarization on either a right–left spectrum or a hawk–dove spectrum appear to be less advantaged in foreign affairs relative to democracies with low to moderate levels of polarization. These analyses suggest that, to the extent there may be consequences of extreme polarization for foreign policy outcomes, these consequences are likely to be negative.

There are limitations to these analyses. The main limitation relates to measurement and data availability. As chapter 1 emphasized, cross-national polarization is hard to measure. Public opinion data on affective polarization is especially limited in geographic and temporal scope. But it is also challenging to measure the foreign policy outcomes of interest in this book. Outcomes for which we have reliable cross-national data tend to be major international events, like starting a war or joining a military alliance. Other important changes in foreign policy, like the shift in cross-strait relations under Taiwanese President Tsai Ing-wen, are not easily identifiable in these types of datasets. Moreover, concepts like credibility and reliability are perceptual outcomes. These outcomes hinge on the perspectives of foreign adversaries and allies rather than behaviors that are easily observed. Such perceptual variables are hard to capture in what international relations scholars term “large-N” cross-national studies.

A second limitation relates to the inferences we can draw from this type of analysis. As discussed in chapter 1, polarization is a structural, multicausal phenomenon. It is not randomly assigned across countries but rather intimately connected with economic, social, and political change. These shifts

also impact a country's foreign policy. This makes it challenging (if not impossible) to isolate the causal effect of polarization on foreign policy outcomes. This is why the analyses in this chapter are not intended to test the theory in chapter 2. Rather, they serve as a sort of "plausibility probe"⁸ for further investigation about whether polarization erodes democratic advantages. Because foundational scholarship from the democratic advantage tradition in international relations largely relies on evidence from cross-national analyses, this is an appropriate starting point. However, the limitations of analyses in this chapter motivate the focus on the relationship between polarization and foreign policymaking in a single country (the United States) in the latter half of this book.

3.1 Cross-National Trends in Polarization

What do we know about trends in partisan polarization globally? To characterize this variation, we need comparable measures of polarization across time and space. A key issue is that scholars disagree about what measures to use. For one, the terms "left" and "right" or "liberal" and "conservative" do not mean the same thing in different political contexts. A political party that the Swedish public considers "center right" may be perceived by the American public to be on the "left." A right-left divide may also not be the only—or even the most—salient political cleavage in a democracy. The disjuncture, for example, between secularists and Islamists in Turkish politics does not neatly map to the right-left spectrum that characterizes politics in neighboring Greece. And in other countries, different dimensions of ideological conflict may be more relevant than the right-left divide. For instance, political scientists Liesbet Hooghe, Gary Marks, and their co-authors characterize parties in many European democracies on the "GAL-TAN" spectrum, which distinguishes between parties that are "green, alternative, and liberal" and those that are "traditional, authoritarian, and nationalist."⁹

Measures of partisan polarization are complicated by the fact that countries have different electoral systems, legislative processes, and policy agendas. When measuring polarization within a country, researchers commonly use legislative roll-call votes to identify the policy positions of political officials or

8. According to Levy (2008, 6), "A plausibility probe is comparable to a pilot study in experimental or survey research. It allows the researcher to sharpen a hypothesis or theory."

9. Hooghe, Marks, and Wilson 2002; Hooghe, Marks, and Kamphorst 2025.

their parties. A similar cross-national approach is difficult because countries have very different policy agendas at any given time.¹⁰

Despite these challenges, researchers offer some ways to measure ideological polarization and affective polarization among politicians (elite polarization) and the public (mass polarization). To measure ideological polarization on a right–left spectrum among politicians, one approach relies on expert surveys to categorize ideological positions of political parties. The Varieties of Democracy project based at the University of Gothenburg draws on expert surveys to code positions of parties on many issue dimensions.¹¹ Expert surveys have strengths and limitations. They are easy to directly interpret, but the assessments of human experts can be subjective and prone to bias.¹² Expert surveys are also limited to specific countries, parties, or years. The Chapel Hill Expert Survey, based at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, for instance, has been conducted every four years since 1999 and focuses on political parties in Europe.¹³

Another approach is to compare parties based on the policy positions they describe in their party platform or manifesto. Party leaders release platforms in advance of upcoming elections to communicate to voters what their party stands for. The Manifesto Project (MARPOR), based at the WZB Berlin Social Science Center, collects these platforms from political parties worldwide and codes policy positions based on statements from each platform.¹⁴ Political scientists then devise ways to measure a party's ideological position based on these coded statements.¹⁵ For example, statements that support capitalism and free-market economics are coded as “right wing,” while those supporting labor and the welfare state are coded as “left wing.”

10. An exception is efforts to compare policy positions of countries in international institutions where votes occur at the country level. For example, political scientists use roll-call votes in UNGA (Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten 2017) to estimate a country's policy preferences. However, since these approaches are focused on foreign policy votes, they do not map neatly onto a right–left spectrum.

11. Lührmann et al. 2020.

12. Bollen and Paxton 2000.

13. Bakker et al. 2020. An expansion of the dataset in 2020 focuses on Latin American parties (Martínez-Gallardo et al. 2023).

14. Lehmann et al. 2018.

15. For example, Laver and Budge (1992) use factor analysis to identify which issues should be considered right wing or left wing and then construct an additive right–left index based on this coding.

In democracies with more than two major parties or multiple salient ideological cleavages, using a right–left index to measure polarization becomes complex. To simplify the comparison between two-party and multiparty systems, I create a dataset that identifies the party (or coalition) of the executive and the party (or coalition) of the primary opposition group. In this dataset, described in more detail later in this chapter, I match democratic leaders identified by the Archigos dataset of political leaders¹⁶ to their respective party platforms in the MARPOR data¹⁷ and then manually identify the party of the primary opposition.¹⁸ I calculate the measure of ideological polarization as the absolute distance between the right–left index of the party or coalition of the executive and that of the opposition for every executive term.

Figure 3.1 shows the median level of ideological distance between the executive and opposition party (or parties) in each country, averaging across all executive terms for each country in the MARPOR database from 1921 to 2022. According to this measure, for much of the twentieth century, the most ideologically polarized countries are Switzerland, France, Denmark, Sweden, and Greece. The United States, highlighted, falls in the middle of this set of countries. While ideological polarization in the United States increased substantially in the twenty-first century, figure 3.1 emphasizes that the average ideological distance between the Democratic and Republican Parties during the full time period is not as large as that between left-wing and right-wing parties in many democracies. Lots of other countries experience similar or even higher levels of ideological polarization.

This figure shows only one of many approaches to measure ideological polarization among political elites cross-nationally. Measuring polarization among the public, or mass polarization, can be even more complex. Some researchers draw inferences about mass polarization from public opinion surveys. The World Values Survey, fielded since 1981 in a large cross-section of countries, asks respondents questions about their partisan affiliation and political ideology. Researchers use these answers to approximate the position of political parties or to create measures of ideological polarization among the public.¹⁹ This can be a tricky process. Even when researchers agree on which

16. Goemans, Gleditsch, and Chiozza 2009.

17. Lehmann et al. 2018.

18. The primary opposition is coded as the party or coalition with the most votes that is not part of the governing coalition (see appendix).

19. See, e.g., Inglehart et al. 2014.

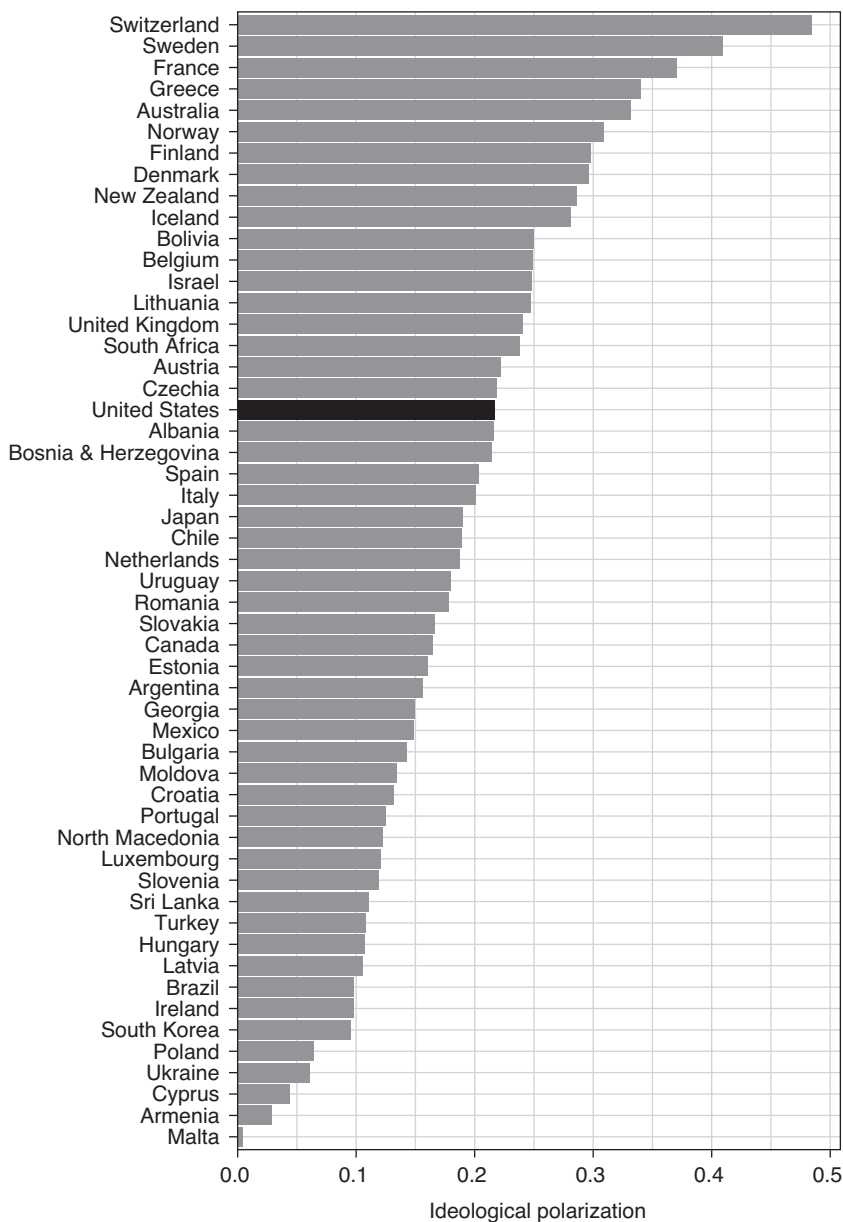


FIGURE 3.1. Median level of ideological polarization between executive and opposition parties

data source to use, questions arise when translating that data source into a measure of polarization. For instance, with data from MARPOR on party platforms, how should the categories of right and left be measured? Should we separate the right–left spectrum into a social and an economic dimension? To calculate polarization, should we incorporate all parties in the measure or just the party of the executive and the opposition? If the former, should we weight the measure by the strength of parties? If weighting, should we weight by total votes or by seats in the legislature? These questions illustrate why political scientists use many different measures of polarization.

Another way to measure mass polarization is to rely on expert judgments. The Digital Society Project, started in 2018, produces a “polarization of society” measure that asks country experts: “How would you characterize the differences of opinions on major political issues in this society?”²⁰ The answer options are coded as: serious polarization, moderate polarization, medium polarization, limited polarization, and no polarization. The geographic coverage of this measure is better than most comparable measures, since experts conceptualize polarization in both autocracies and democracies. According to the data, roughly 27 percent of country-years between 2000 and 2023 were considered by experts to be “seriously polarized.”

Figure 3.2 shows how this measure of mass polarization has changed since 2000. Countries where polarization has increased (decreased) according to this measure are in black (gray). Countries that saw no changes in this period, or for which data is missing, are in white. The figure shows that the level of mass polarization has increased in many countries since the beginning of the twenty-first century. It is notable that sharp increases have occurred in many advanced democracies. Countries with the largest increases in polarization are concentrated in Europe, the Americas, and South Asia. By contrast, levels of mass polarization in sub-Saharan Africa and East Asia have remained relatively stable. In only a handful of countries has polarization decreased since 2000.

Research on cross-national affective polarization—the tendency of people to like their in-party and dislike their out-party—is thin but rapidly growing. The primary approach to measuring affective polarization is to draw on data from the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems (CSES), a public opinion survey conducted since 1996 in twenty democracies. The CSES asks participants to rate each political party on a scale from 0 (strongly dislike) to 10 (strongly like). Researchers then calculate measures of affective

20. Mechkova et al. 2024.

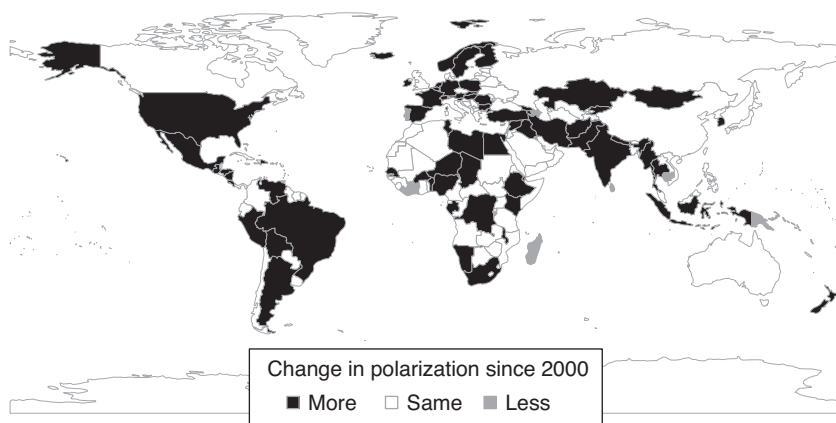


FIGURE 3.2. Change in level of polarization in society using data from the Digital Society Project (2000–2023)

polarization based on how survey respondents rate their in-party versus their out-party. In *American Affective Polarization in Comparative Perspective*, political scientists Noam Gidron, James Adams, and Will Horne compare ratings from supporters of the largest left-wing party and the largest right-wing party in each country.²¹ A larger gap in ratings signifies a higher level of affective polarization. By their calculations, between 1996 and 2017, the three countries in the sample with the highest level of affective polarization were Spain, Greece, and Portugal. The three countries with the lowest levels of affective polarization were the Netherlands, Finland, and Iceland. The United States is not an extreme outlier but rather falls in the middle, ranking as having the eighth highest level of affective polarization of the twenty countries in their study.²²

Political scientist Andres Reiljan and his coauthors take a similar approach in constructing an index of affective polarization based on CSES survey data, but they weight the evaluations of parties based on their size.²³ Figure 3.3 shows the level of affective polarization in 2020 calculated from the last CSES survey conducted in each country.²⁴ Because the CSES surveys began in the 1990s and are not fielded annually in each country, researchers are limited in

21. Gidron, Adams, and Horne 2020.

22. Gidron, Adams, and Horne 2020, 23.

23. Reiljan 2020; Reiljan et al. 2023.

24. Data from Reiljan 2020.

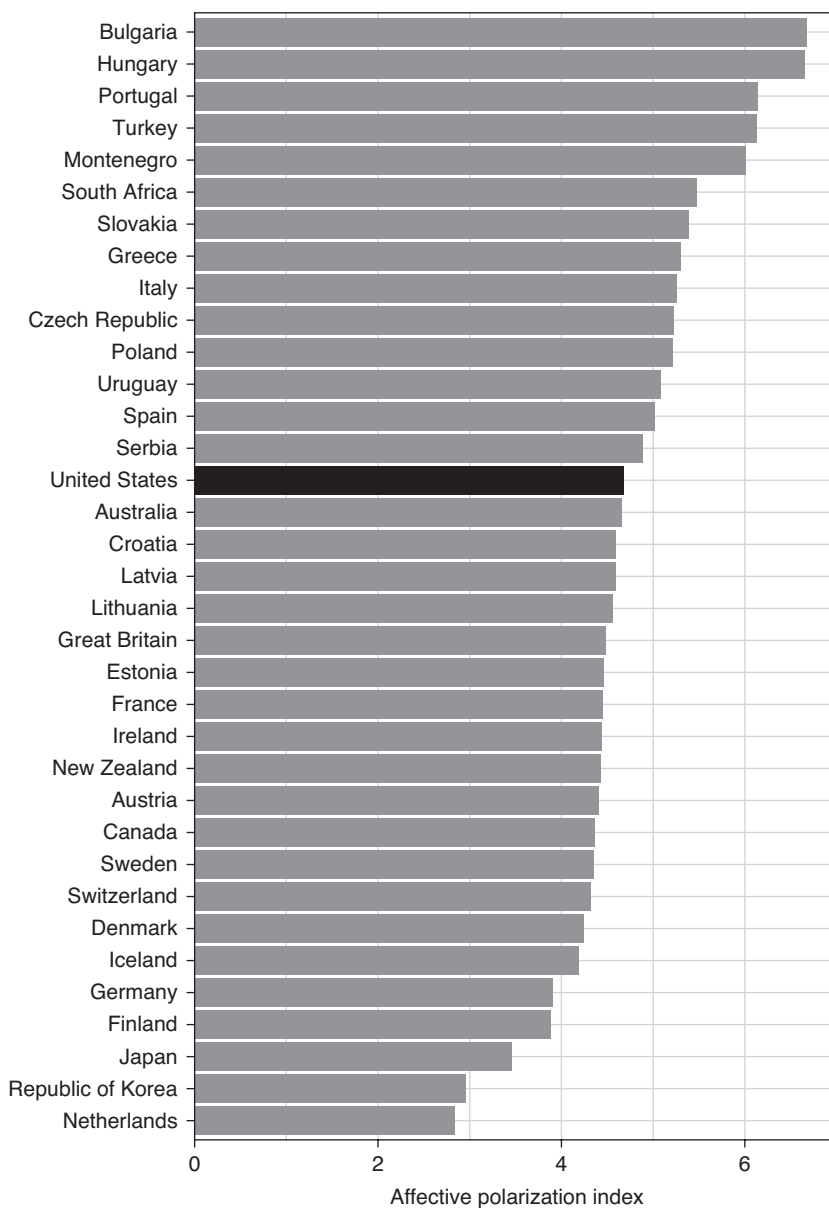


FIGURE 3.3. Affective polarization index calculated by Reiljan (2020) from recent public opinion surveys conducted by the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems

their ability to generate more fine-grained cross-national measures of affective polarization. This data also suggests that the United States falls at middling levels of polarization. In this figure, the United States ranks as the fifteenth most affectively polarized democracies out of thirty-five democracies in the sample. According to Reiljan's measure, affective polarization in the United States has grown very sharply over the past two decades. In the 1990s, the United States was not nearly as affectively polarized as it is in the 2020s.

Although there are many ways to conceptualize and measure ideological and affective polarization cross-nationally, a few trends are worth emphasizing. For one, most research suggests that mass polarization has increased in the twenty-first century and has been particularly problematic since the mid-2010s. The growth in polarization is not limited to new democracies but rather affects a wide range of countries. Those in Europe and the Americas have struggled in particular. In addition, while the United States is clearly polarized, other democracies experience similar problems with growing ideological polarization, affective polarization, or both. This means that the United States is not an outlier when it comes to polarized politics. Since the mid-2010s, however, the United States has experienced very high levels of both affective and ideological polarization that are unique in the country's recent history. According to many of these measures, it would be reasonable to characterize American politics in the 2020s as "extremely polarized."

3.1.1 *Measuring Polarization for Cross-National Analyses*

The objective of this book is to explore the relationship between extreme polarization and foreign policy outcomes. To characterize this relationship, I look for a cross-national measure of polarization that does three things. First, the measure needs to focus on the executive, such as a prime minister, president, chancellor, or the equivalent position. Many cross-national measures of polarization capture polarization within legislatures. Yet, in presidential systems where the president is responsible for making foreign policy, measures of legislative polarization are less useful than measures of ideological distance between the president and the opposition party.

Second, the measure must have good spatial and temporal coverage. This is needed to trace how polarization correlates with foreign policy outcomes within a given country over time. Many interesting survey-based measures of polarization, including measures of cross-national affective polarization, rely on data from public opinion surveys. As previously discussed, these surveys

are limited in the sample of countries and years that they cover, making them less useful in characterizing long-term change within countries.

Third, ideally the measure of polarization could also characterize partisan divergence on aspects of foreign affairs. Most cross-national measures of ideological polarization focus on economic and/or social issues arrayed on a conservative–liberal or right–left spectrum. However, ideological preferences on a right–left scale are distinct from (although may be correlated with) foreign policy preferences that capture the relative hawkishness of political parties and their leaders.

I construct a new dataset that develops multiple measures of polarization to meet these conditions. This dataset begins with a crosswalk of two well-known existing resources. The first is the Archigos dataset on political leaders, collected by researchers at the University of Essex, the University of Rochester, and Vanderbilt University.²⁵ The second is the MARPOR dataset on party platforms, based at WZB Berlin.²⁶ Since my focus is on executives, I use the Archigos data to determine the leader of each democracy in a given country-year. I reorganize the Archigos data into executive terms because party platforms are released in conjunction with elections.²⁷ For example, the observation ID for U.S. President George W. Bush, who served two consecutive four-year terms, in the Archigos dataset is USA-2001. In the new dataset, President Bush would receive two entries, USA-2001 and USA-2005, one for each term in office.

After separating the data by executive terms, I manually match each leader listed in the Archigos leaders dataset with their political party in the MARPOR, locating the most recent party platform that corresponds to their election. MARPOR collects and codes political party platforms in fifty-five democracies for which platforms are publicly available.²⁸ Platforms or manifestos are statements released in advance of elections that describe the goals and values of a political party or candidate running for office. The advantage of looking at party platforms is that they provide clear policy positions before a party is in office. Rather than inferring a party's policy positions from political behavior, one can assess how well the party's stated positions align with

25. Goemans, Gleditsch, and Chiozza 2009.

26. Lehmann et al. 2018.

27. I code the first year of the executive term as year t if the election occurs between January and May of year t , or as year $t + 1$ if the election occurs June through December.

28. Lehmann et al. 2018.

policy outcomes. Another advantage of the MARPOR data is that it provides insights into policy preferences on many dimensions, including foreign policy preferences.²⁹

The MARPOR data records the percent of votes each party receives and the percent of total seats the party obtains in the legislature. But, in some instances, the executive—typically a president or prime minister—is not from the majority party in legislature. This may be the case, for example, in presidential systems where legislators and executives are elected independently. It could also be the case in parliamentary systems ruled by a coalition in which the prime minister comes from a minority party.³⁰ This motivates the cross-walk between Archigos and MARPOR to identify the political party of the executive rather than the majority party in the legislature. In addition to identifying the party or coalition to which the executive belongs, I also record the party or coalition of the primary opposition group. To simplify the comparison between two-party and multiparty systems, the opposition party is defined as the party or coalition with the most votes that is not part of the governing coalition. Using the MARPOR data, I identify positions of the executive and opposition parties on both a right–left dimension and a hawk–dove dimension as a basis for constructing measures of polarization and extreme polarization.

3.1.2 *Right–Left and Hawk–Dove Polarization*

A right–left dimension captures whether a party is a conservative or liberal. Economically, parties on the right tend to support the free market and oppose government intervention in the economy; parties on the left tend to support government regulation of the economy and expansion of the welfare state. Socially, parties on the right support traditional sources of authority and morals, while parties on the left support social change. A *hawk–dove* dimension captures positions on foreign policy. The relative hawkishness of a party reflects how willing they are to use military force to address international problems. Intuitively, whether polarization will impact foreign policy depends in part on the dimension on which party preferences diverge. It is possible for

29. Alternative potential data sources, like the Database of Political Institutions from the World Bank (Scartascini, Cruz, and Keefer 2021), include indicators for a right–left dimension but not for other policy dimensions.

30. See appendix for coding rules.

political parties to differ on domestic issues but agree on foreign affairs, or vice versa.

To calculate the right–left position of the executive and opposition party, I follow a coding scheme from the MARPOR project that identifies right-wing and left-wing ideas in policy platforms.³¹ I use the total number of “right” statements and “left” statements in each platform in the MARPOR dataset. I then measure the right–left position of a given political party based on a measure proposed by Kenneth Schultz.³² This measure ranges from approximately 0 (all statements are left leaning) to 1 (all statements are right leaning). To reduce noise, the approach developed by Schultz biases the measure toward 0.5 for platforms in which there is relatively little information. I construct this measure cumulatively, such that successive platforms generate more information about the party.

$$\text{Right–Left Position} = \frac{\text{right} + 1}{\text{right} + \text{left} + 2}$$

To measure polarization over foreign policy, I repeat the same process, using MARPOR codes of positive or negative statements about militarism in each of the party platforms. The hawk–dove position measures the relative hawkishness of the parties, with higher values indicating more favorability toward militarization and the use of military force.

$$\text{Hawk–Dove Position} = \frac{\text{milpos} + 1}{\text{milpos} + \text{milneg} + 2}$$

These dimensions are measured separately because although the right–left and hawk–dove dimension are positively correlated, the correlation is weak ($\rho \approx 0.13$). There are many political systems in which parties on the right are not necessarily more hawkish than parties on the left. The conventional expectation is that hawkish parties tend to be more ideologically conservative (e.g., Likud Party in Israel) and dovish parties tend to be more ideologically liberal (e.g., French Socialist Party). However, we also see instances of dovish parties on the right, like the Croatian Democratic Union, which is economically conservative but has an anti-interventionist foreign policy. We also observe hawkish parties on the left, like the Norwegian Labour party, which,

31. Laver and Budge 1992.

32. Schultz 1995.

while economically liberal, has historically been anti-communist and a strong supporter of NATO.

From these two dimensions, I create measures of both right–left and hawk–dove polarization for a given executive term. After matching the corresponding opposition party with their party platform data in MARPOR, I calculate the distance in ideological position between the executive party/coalition (indexed by e_i) and the opposition party/coalition (indexed by o_i) in a given country (i) at any one point and time (t). I measure polarization on both a right–left and hawk–dove dimension for all executive terms in the dataset. right–left and hawk–dove measures of polarization are also positively correlated, although again the correlation is weak ($\rho \approx 0.18$).

$$\text{Right–Left Polarization}_{it} = \left| \frac{\text{right}_{e_i t} + 1}{\text{right}_{e_i t} + \text{left}_{e_i t} + 2} - \frac{\text{right}_{o_i t} + 1}{\text{right}_{o_i t} + \text{left}_{o_i t} + 2} \right|$$

$$\text{Hawk–Dove Polarization}_{it} = \left| \frac{\text{milpos}_{e_i t} + 1}{\text{milpos}_{e_i t} + \text{milneg}_{e_i t} + 2} - \frac{\text{milpos}_{o_i t} + 1}{\text{milpos}_{o_i t} + \text{milneg}_{o_i t} + 2} \right|$$

3.1.3 Extreme Polarization

The theory in chapter 2 focused on how extreme polarization, in which countries experience high levels of both ideological and affective polarization simultaneously, has negative consequences for foreign policymaking. One of the main ideas in this book is that, while more moderate levels of polarization help to confer some of the advantages that democracies have in foreign affairs, extreme forms of polarization can undermine these advantages.

As previously discussed in this chapter, however, cross-national data on affective polarization is very limited. Therefore, in the analyses that follow, I focus on extreme levels of ideological polarization. I code polarization as *extreme* on either a right–left or a hawk–dove dimension in a given executive term if it is at the ninetieth percentile or above across the full sample of executive terms in the dataset for the respective dimension.

Many contemporary examples of societies experiencing extreme right–left polarization are well known. For instance, the polarization measure classifies two recent executive terms in the United States (President Donald Trump’s

first term from 2017 to 2021 and President Joe Biden's term from 2021 to 2025) as extreme on a right–left dimension. Since the mid-twentieth century, American politics has shifted from relatively low levels of right–left and hawk–dove polarization in the mid-twentieth century to relatively high levels of right–left polarization in the twenty-first century. Today, the Republican and Democratic Parties tend to be farther apart on social and economic issues, but they do not differ substantially on foreign policy issues. Other countries experience high levels of hawk–dove polarization but low to middling levels of right–left polarization. For example, in some Eastern European countries, parties strongly disagree about their orientation with respect to relations with the EU, NATO (North Atlantic Treaty Organization), and Russia, exhibiting greater partisan divergence on a hawk–dove dimension.

Instances of extreme polarization are not concentrated within a small group of countries. According to the measure constructed for this chapter, roughly half of countries in the dataset (twenty-seven out of fifty-five countries) experienced extreme polarization on either the right–left or hawk–dove spectrum at some point in the MARPOR dataset. And 80 percent of countries experienced high levels of polarization on either dimension, falling at the seventy-fifth percentile or above. This suggests that polarization is an important feature—sometimes occasionally, and sometimes in a more sustained way—of democratic politics.

The approach that the rest of this chapter takes is to incorporate these measures of extreme polarization into well-known, existing analyses of the three democratic advantages: the stability, credibility, and reliability advantages. We should think of the analyses that follow not as a test of different hypotheses, but rather as a descriptive first cut to investigate the association between polarization and democratic foreign policy.

3.2 Polarization and Foreign Policy Stability

The dominant view among international relations scholars is that democracies have a stability advantage in foreign affairs.³³ Despite the fact that democracies experience more frequent leader turnover on average, they tend to maintain consistent foreign policies relative to non-democracies. As described in chapter 2, this stability advantage arises from two systems of constraint on

33. See, e.g., Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel 2009; McGillivray and Smith 2008; Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll 2015; Smith 2016.

political power. Vertical constraints make democratic leaders accountable to the public through regular elections. Politicians campaigning for nationwide office have incentives to appeal to a median voter in the electorate and pursue foreign policies that provide public goods and maximize national welfare. Horizontal constraints, such as the presence of an active political opposition and the existence of a nonpartisan foreign policy bureaucracy, check democratic leaders and make them less inclined to pursue ideologically extreme policies.

There is considerable empirical support for the stability advantage. To demonstrate the stability of democratic foreign policy, a common approach is to look at the association between regime type (i.e., whether a country is a democracy or not) and changes in foreign policy positions over time. For instance, scholars examine patterns of roll-call votes at UNGA to show that foreign policy remains consistent in democracies. UNGA roll-call votes are used to generate ideal point estimates of the foreign policy positions of countries in a given year.³⁴ This measure is advantageous because it lends itself to cross-national comparisons; all countries vote on the same set of issues at the same time. UNGA roll-call votes are also useful because they include votes on many topics related to foreign affairs rather than a single issue area like trade policy. Because the votes in UNGA are nonbinding, they are thought to reflect sincerely expressed foreign policy positions.³⁵

UNGA voting patterns emphasize that democratic foreign policy is not particularly volatile. Political scientist Alastair Smith, for example, shows that leader turnover in autocracies is associated with large changes in UN ideal point estimates, but turnover in democracies is not.³⁶ Political scientists Ashley Leeds, Michaela Mattes, and their coauthors analyze the impacts of both leader and party turnover on foreign policy stability.³⁷ Their analyses corroborate Smith's finding that leader turnover does not significantly impact patterns of UN voting in democracies. However, they go an additional step further to show that a change in the societal supporting coalition of a leader—for example, a change in the party of the executive—does not affect foreign policy in democracies but does affect autocratic foreign policy.

34. Voeten, Strezhnev, and Bailey 2009; Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten 2017; Voeten 2021.

35. Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten 2017.

36. Smith 2016.

37. Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll 2015; Mattes, Leeds, and Matsumura 2016; Leeds and Mattes 2022.

In *Domestic Interests, Democracy, and Foreign Policy Change*, Ashley Leeds and Michaela Mattes show that this pattern holds across other domains of foreign policy.³⁸

This book does not dispute the overarching logic behind the stability advantage. However, it emphasizes that there is variation among democracies that comes from different levels of polarization. Periods of extreme polarization within democracies should be associated with more volatility in foreign policy. This should especially be the case in areas of foreign affairs where executives exercise substantial discretion. Many foreign policy decisions do not require formal domestic approval processes like popular referenda or legislative votes. As a plausibility probe for the relationship between polarization and foreign policy stability, I replicate and extend existing research by Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll who study patterns of regime type and UNGA voting.³⁹

In table 3.1, the unit of analysis is the country-year, and the sample extends from 1946 to 2008. The dependent variable “*change in UN voting*” captures the magnitude of the annual change in a country’s foreign policy position. This variable is calculated as the absolute difference in the country’s estimated ideal point (constructed from UNGA roll-call votes) relative to the previous year.⁴⁰ Larger values of the dependent variable indicate larger changes in foreign policy preferences, and therefore less foreign policy stability. The model includes control variables from Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll’s original analysis that contribute to volatility in foreign policy: indicators for whether or not the country had a defense pact with the United States (“*U.S. ally*”) or the Soviet Union (“*USSR ally*”), indicators for the period from 1989 to 1991 that spans the end of the Cold War when many countries experienced major domestic and foreign policy changes (“*Cold War end*”), and an indicator for whether a country experienced a regime change (“*regime transition*”).⁴¹ Each model also includes country fixed-effects with standard errors clustered by country. This means that comparisons are made within the same country over time.

38. Leeds and Mattes 2022.

39. Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll 2015.

40. See Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten 2017 for data on UNGA roll-call votes. Following the original analyses, this variable is log-transformed to better approximate a normal distribution.

41. The authors code regime transitions as country-years in which a country transitioned from a democracy to a nondemocracy or vice versa, based on the value of the country’s polity score (Marshall and Gurr 2018). They code countries scoring a six or above democracies.

TABLE 3.1. Replication and extension of Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll (2015)

	Change in UN voting			
	<i>Full sample</i>	<i>Democracies only</i>		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Extreme right–left polarization			0.130 (0.106)	
Extreme hawk–dove polarization				0.675*** (0.173)
SOLS change	0.178*** (0.053)	0.055 (0.070)	0.143 (0.092)	0.150 (0.092)
Other leader transition	0.072 (0.059)	0.044 (0.088)	0.086 (0.108)	0.076 (0.107)
Democracy	−0.360*** (0.051)			
Cold War end	0.058 (0.062) (0.107)	0.097 (0.103)	0.003 (0.141)	−0.026 (0.140)
U.S. ally	−0.143 (0.092)	−0.300** (0.124)	−0.269* (0.143)	−0.277* (0.142)
USSR ally	0.078 (0.124)	0.487** (0.221)	0.545** (0.233)	0.602*** (0.232)
Country FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	7,049	2,731	1,383	1,383

Note: *p < 0.1; **p < 0.05; ***p < 0.01

Model 1 in the table replicates Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll's original model, which includes data from both democratic and nondemocratic countries. The first thing to note in this model is that the coefficient on “*democracy*” is negative and statistically significant. This emphasizes the existence of a democratic stability advantage: on average, democracies tend to experience less volatility in their foreign policy positions relative to nondemocracies. The researchers also look at the relationship between leader turnover and foreign policy stability. They draw a distinction between a change in the societal coalition supporting a leader (what they term a “*SOLS change*”) and other forms of leadership turnover that do not involve a major transition of power (“*other leader transition*”). Importantly, the coefficient on “*SOLS change*” is positive and statistically significant, whereas the coefficient on “*other leader transition*” is not. Only

leader transitions that involve a change in the societal coalition supporting a leader (for example, a change in the party controlling the executive in a democracy), are associated with major foreign policy changes.

Models 2 through 4 extend the analysis by focusing only on the subset of democratic countries in the sample. Model 2 is the baseline model that includes the control variables from model 1.⁴² Here, we see that among democracies, the coefficient on “*SOLS change*” is positive but no longer statistically significant at conventional levels. As Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll (2015) explain, this suggests that the relationship observed in model 1 is mainly driven by instability within non-democracies. In democracies, party changes are not correlated with foreign policy volatility, on average. Models 3 and 4 extend the analyses by adding in new measures of “*extreme right-left polarization*” (model 3) and “*extreme hawk-dove polarization*” (model 4) in democracies. Both measures are positively associated with changes in UN voting patterns, indicating more instability in foreign policy. However, only the coefficient on “*extreme hawk-dove polarization*” (model 4) is statistically significant. The magnitude of this coefficient is also quite sizeable; it corresponds to roughly 0.5 standard deviations of the dependent variable.

The models in table 3.1 emphasize a few takeaways. The first is that democracies, on average, tend to have more stable foreign policies than nondemocracies. Even leader turnover and party turnover in democracies is not associated with major fluctuations in democratic foreign policy. This reaffirms the democratic stability advantage identified by many international relations scholars. However, the table also suggests that some democracies behave differently than other democracies. In particular, democracies experiencing periods of extreme polarization may display less foreign policy stability. Countries experiencing higher degrees of hawk-dove polarization may be especially volatile in their foreign policy positions.

3.3 Polarization and Democratic Credibility

Beyond the stability advantage, chapter 2 described additional advantages that democracies have relative to nondemocracies when making foreign policy.

42. *Democracy* and *regime transition* are not included in these models because all country-years in this subset are democracies, none of which experiences regime changes.

For one, responsiveness to the public and accountability to the political opposition makes democratic leaders unlikely to issue threats or promises that they cannot keep. As a result, the threats and promises they do make should be taken seriously by foreign adversaries, giving democracies a credibility advantage. Credibility is hard to evaluate because it is a perceptual outcome. We can observe changes in foreign policy that indicate stability or instability, but whether or not a country's threats and promises are credible hinges on the perceptions of other countries.

Fortunately, existing research on democratic credibility identifies some observable implications of the credibility advantage in international relations. A well-known implication comes from Kenneth Schultz's *Democracy and Coercive Diplomacy*.⁴³ Schultz's insight is that, because coercive threats made by democracies are, on average, perceived as more credible, their adversaries are less likely to respond to democratic challengers with militarized action. To test his theory, Schultz focuses on the relationship between a country that starts a dispute (initiator), often by issuing a coercive demand, and the intended recipient of the demand (target) in the context of a militarized interstate dispute, or MID. MIDs are conflicts between countries that fall short of major war. Data on these disputes is collected by the Correlates of War Project, which started at University of Michigan in the 1960s.⁴⁴ Schultz's theory predicts that disputes initiated by democracies are less likely to be reciprocated relative to disputes initiated by nondemocracies. A MID is considered reciprocated when a target takes a militarized action (like mobilizing troops or using force) in response to a coercive demand.

The theory in chapter 2 of this book does not dispute the argument that democracies may be, on average, more credible relative to nondemocracies. Rather, it suggests there should be variation among democracies in terms of their perceived credibility. Democracies experiencing extreme polarization should be less credible in issuing threats. Chapter 2 explained that, in highly polarized times, partisans place more value on scoring political wins or seeing their preferred policy enacted rather than other considerations in the policymaking process. Politicians from the opposing party have incentives to actively oppose the executive's foreign policy agenda. The erosion of vertical

43. Schultz 2001a.

44. Palmer et al. 2020.

and horizontal constraints undermines the credibility of signals sent to foreign adversaries.

To probe the relationship between extreme polarization and credibility, I replicate and extend Schultz's canonical models of democratic credibility in table 3.2.⁴⁵ All models in this table are logistic regression models in which the dependent variable ("*MID reciprocation*") is an indicator for whether the dispute was reciprocated by the target country. Model 1 replicates the pooled Schultz model, which includes disputes initiated both by democracies and nondemocracies. The key independent variable in model 1 is an indicator for whether the dispute was started by a democracy ("*democratic initiator*"). The coefficient on "*democratic initiator*" is negative and statistically significant, showing that MIDs started by democracies are less likely to be reciprocated relative to those initiated by nondemocracies. Schultz takes the main implication of this finding to be that democracies have a credibility advantage in interstate disputes.

Models 2 through 4 extend Schultz's model. The sample in these models is composed only of disputes initiated by democracies. Model 2 is the baseline model, which includes a set of other factors that Schultz identifies as potentially impacting the likelihood that a MID is reciprocated. These control variables are: indicators for power asymmetries between the countries in dispute (whether the initiator and/or the target of the dispute was a major power or a minor power), the initiator's share of capabilities, whether the countries in dispute are contiguous (i.e., whether they share a geographic border), foreign policy similarity (measured by the similarity of alliance portfolios), and the type of issue in dispute (i.e., whether the dispute was over territory, policy, etc.).⁴⁶

Models 3 and 4 add indicators of "*extreme right-left polarization*" (model 3) and "*extreme hawk-dove polarization*" (model 4) to the baseline model. The theory in chapter 2 suggests that democracies experiencing extreme polarization are perceived as less credible than democracies that are not experiencing extreme polarization. This means that disputes initiated by extremely polarized democracies should be *more* likely to be reciprocated. In model 3, the coefficient on "*extreme right-left polarization*" is in the expected direction (positive) but is substantively small and not statistically significant at

45. This replication uses data from Downes and Sechser (2012), who reconstruct analyses from Schultz 2001a.

46. See Schultz 2001a for a discussion of these control variables.

TABLE 3.2. Replication and extension of Schultz (2001a)

	MID reciprocation			
	<i>Full sample</i>	<i>Democracies only</i>		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Democratic initiator	−0.468** (0.188)			
Democratic target	0.005 (0.166)			
Both democratic	0.500 (0.363)			
Extreme right–left polarization			0.034 (0.648)	
Extreme hawk–dove polarization				2.672** (1.272)
Major initiator–major target	−0.508** (0.247)	−0.591 (0.595)	0.249 (1.047)	0.367 (1.059)
Major initiator–minor target	−0.359* (0.186)	0.484 (0.467)	0.315 (0.981)	0.145 (1.001)
Minor initiator–major target	0.174 (0.248)	0.739 (0.539)	3.255** (1.273)	3.378** (1.322)
Initiator's share of capabilities	0.111 (0.247)	−0.095 (0.526)	2.492* (1.373)	2.730* (1.413)
Contiguous	0.594*** (0.158)	0.388 (0.335)	−0.735 (0.537)	−0.638 (0.552)
Alliance portfolio similarity	−0.113 (0.202)	0.119 (0.487)	−0.302 (1.108)	−0.134 (1.150)
Status quo evaluation of initiator	0.181 (0.188)	−0.118 (0.424)	−1.889** (0.944)	−2.038** (0.966)
Status quo evaluation of target	−0.476** (0.193)	−0.177 (0.428)	0.011 (0.855)	−0.072 (0.886)
Territory	0.298* (0.173)	0.302 (0.373)		
Government	0.311 (0.386)	−0.412 (0.758)	−2.242 (1.466)	−3.211** (1.638)
Policy	−1.203*** (0.158)	−1.600*** (0.338)	−1.839*** (0.509)	−1.979*** (0.531)
Other	−0.491 (0.593)	−0.843 (1.276)		
Constant	0.214 (0.243)	0.075 (0.501)	−0.099 (0.852)	−0.222 (0.868)
Observations	1,153	286	117	117

Note: *p < 0.1; **p < 0.05; ***p < 0.01

conventional levels. In model 4, however, the coefficient on “*extreme hawk–dove polarization*” is positive and statistically significant. Countries targeted in a dispute initiated by a democracy experiencing extreme polarization in foreign policy appear more likely to respond with militarized action, on average. To be more concrete, a substantive interpretation of the baseline model (model 1) predicts that MIDs initiated by nondemocracies are reciprocated in roughly 40 percent of cases, but MIDs initiated by democracies are reciprocated less frequently in roughly 30 percent of cases.⁴⁷ Model 4 suggests that, on average, MIDs initiated by extremely polarized democracies are reciprocated in upwards of 75 percent of cases.

Again, this type of analysis is suggestive but not definitive. Some other scholars have taken issue with Schultz’s approach to measuring democratic credibility by using a country’s behavior during an interstate dispute.⁴⁸ This analysis is also limited to relatively few observations because only 117 disputes initiated by democracies appear both in Schultz’s data and in MARPOR data. This means that the results are driven only by a few cases of countries experiencing extreme polarization. As a result, it difficult to discern systematic or persistent patterns. However, table 3.2 implies that democracies seem to be more credible than nondemocracies (model 1), but that democracies experiencing extreme polarization on foreign policy issues may be *less* credible relative to other democracies (model 4).

3.4 Polarization and Reliability of Commitments

The final advantage introduced in chapter 2 was the reliability advantage. International relations scholars find that democracies tend to be better at making and keeping international commitments. Domestic constraints provide incentives for leaders to pursue cooperative policies and avoid reneging on international commitments. As a result, democracies should be more reliable partners relative to nondemocracies.

Like credibility, reliability is perceptual. What matters is the perspective of current or potential allies and partners, which is hard to measure. Nevertheless, there are some indicators of a country’s tendency to follow through on its commitments. Perhaps the most common approach to assess

47. This interpretation uses a “typical” case of an interstate crisis between a democracy and a nondemocracy that are minor powers, are geographically contiguous, and have a conflict over policy. All continuous variables are held at their medians.

48. See, e.g., Downes and Sechser 2012.

how likely a country is to make or break international commitments is to look at patterns of alliance violation.⁴⁹ The Alliance Treaty Obligations and Provisions (ATOP) project, housed at Rice University, collects data on *military alliances*, which ATOP defines as, “formal agreement[s] among independent states to cooperate militarily in the face of potential or realized military conflict.”⁵⁰ Because alliances are among the most important international commitments, violations of these agreements should create major concerns about a country’s reliability.

One consistent finding in the literature on alliance politics is that democratic alliances tend to be more durable.⁵¹ Democracies are less likely to violate alliance agreements than their non-democratic peers.⁵² Chapter 2, however, argued that democracies vary in terms of the reliability of their commitments. In extremely polarized democracies, institutional constraints on democratic governance are eroded. Highly partisan voters that want their party or policy to win are unlikely to demand that leaders uphold democratic norms and procedures when entering into or exiting from international commitments. They are also less likely to be concerned about the reputational costs of renegeing on an agreement, weakening the vertical constraints that reinforce democratic commitments. At the same time, leaders in polarized contexts have more incentives to circumvent the opposition when making international agreements, weakening horizontal constraints. This should make heavily polarized democracies more likely to renege on commitments and less likely to be perceived as reliable allies.

To explore the relationship between extreme polarization and democratic reliability, table 3.3 replicates and extends canonical work by political scientists Ashley Leeds, Michaela Mattes, and Jeremy Vogel, who theorize about how a country’s interests and political institutions shape decisions to violate alliance agreements.⁵³ The sample in these models includes military alliances from 1919 to 1989 in the Alliance Treaty Obligations and Provisions dataset, and the unit of analysis is the alliance member-year. Following Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel, all models in table 3.3 are logistic regression models with controls for temporal dependence⁵⁴ and standard errors clustered by alliance.

49. See, e.g., Leeds 2003; Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel 2009; Leeds and Savun 2007; LeVeck and Narang 2017; Mattes 2012.

50. Leeds et al. 2002.

51. Gaubatz 1996.

52. Leeds and Savun 2007; Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel 2009.

53. Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel 2009.

54. Carter and Signorino 2010.

TABLE 3.3. Replication and extension of Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel (2009)

	Alliance violation					
	<i>Full sample</i>			<i>Democracies only</i>		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Leader change	0.446 (0.315)		0.910 (0.568)			
SOLS change		0.889** (0.436)		0.213 (0.778)		
Extreme right-left polarization					3.329*** (0.716)	
Extreme hawk-dove polarization						0.976 (2.027)
Change in international power	0.817** (0.327)	0.803** (0.331)	0.062 (1.096)	0.020 (1.067)	17.602*** (1.825)	17.663*** (0.589)
Change in political institutions	0.150 (0.306)	0.131 (0.308)	-0.852 (1.092)	-0.866 (1.115)	-2.630* (1.544)	-1.434 (1.171)
Decrease in threat for this state or increase in threat for ally	0.424 (0.273)	0.421 (0.271)	-1.049 (0.648)	-0.992 (0.646)	-0.910 (1.644)	-0.691 (1.373)
New outside alliance	1.091*** (0.254)	1.070*** (0.254)	0.649 (0.582)	0.698 (0.589)	-17.291*** (0.725)	-17.561*** (0.932)
Democratic state	-1.217*** (0.360)	-1.322*** (0.393)				

One major + one minor power	-0.417 (0.258)	-0.408 (0.259)	0.474 (0.939)	0.483 (0.919)	16.205*** (1.441)	16.597*** (1.303)
Nonmilitary cooperation	-0.744*** (0.259)	-0.746*** (0.258)	-0.715 (0.820)	-0.706 (0.853)	0.419 (1.359)	0.313 (1.364)
Treaty requiring ratification	-0.091 (0.358)	-0.083 (0.355)	-0.412 (0.812)	-0.275 (0.828)	-1.631* (0.924)	-1.492* (0.894)
Peacetime military coordination	0.557*** (0.180)	0.557*** (0.180)	-0.369 (0.311)	-0.401 (0.330)	0.200 (0.939)	0.070 (1.133)
Time	-0.090 (0.078)	-0.086 (0.077)	-0.181 (0.170)	-0.143 (0.181)	0.305 (0.399)	-0.074 (0.546)
Time squared	0.001 (0.004)	0.001 (0.004)	0.023 (0.014)	0.020 (0.015)	0.005 (0.036)	0.020 (0.041)
Time cubed	0.00001 (0.0001)	0.00002 (0.0001)	-0.001* (0.0003)	-0.0005 (0.0003)	-0.0003 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)
Constant	-4.465*** (0.437)	-4.448*** (0.441)	-4.813*** (1.457)	-4.649*** (1.381)	-42.599*** (1.935)	-39.734*** (1.769)
Observations	6,612	6,612	1,865	1,865	1,101	1,101

Note: * p < 0.1; ** p < 0.05; *** p < 0.01

Across all models, the dependent variable (“*alliance violation*”) is an indicator for whether the alliance was violated by an alliance member in a given year. Models 1 and 2 include the full sample of countries used by Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel (2009), which pool together alliance members that are democracies and nondemocracies.⁵⁵ The models also include control variables that could explain a country’s decision to violate existing alliance commitments: shifts in international power, changes in the country’s domestic political institutions, changes in the threat environment, the formation of a new outside alliance, the level of democracy within the state, power asymmetries within the alliance, and key features of the alliance agreement (for example, whether the agreement requires domestic ratification and/or includes nonmilitary cooperation or peacetime military coordination).

Using the full sample of alliance members, models 1 and 2 show key takeaways identified by Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel. In model 1, the coefficient on “*leader change*” is not statistically significant at conventional levels, which suggests no systematic association between a change in leadership within a given alliance member and a corresponding alliance violation. However, as seen in model 2, when pooling together the sample of democracies and nondemocracies, a “*SOLS change*” (a change in the societal coalition supporting a leader, such as a turnover of the executive party in a democracy) is associated with an increased likelihood of alliance violation. Finally, in both models 1 and 2, the coefficient on “*democratic state*” is negative and statistically significant, emphasizing that, on average, democracies are less likely than nondemocracies to violate alliance commitments.

Models 3 through 6 extend the analysis from Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel by focusing only on the subsample of democratic alliance members. Within democracies, “*leader change*” (model 3) and “*SOLS change*” (model 4) do not appear to be correlated with alliance violations. Importantly, model 4 shows that turnover of the executive party does not result in substantial shifts in alliance behavior. This finding emphasizes that the results in model 2 are largely driven by foreign policy instability in nondemocracies, consistent with findings from Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel.

Models 5 and 6 introduce indicators for “*extreme right–left polarization*” (model 5) and “*extreme hawk–dove polarization*” (model 6). Both of the coefficients are in the expected direction (positive), but only the coefficient on

55. Model 2 in table 3.3 replicates model 1 in table 1 in Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel 2009.

“*extreme right–left polarization*” is statistically significant at conventional levels. Model 5 suggests that countries with very high levels of right–left polarization are, on average, more likely to violate their alliance commitments relative to democracies that do not face similar levels of domestic polarization.

In interpreting these models, it is important to emphasize that alliance violations are pretty rare. Across the full sample, violations occur in only 1.1 percent of alliance member-years. A substantive interpretation of model 5 suggests that, holding all other variables at their median values, extremely polarized democracies violate alliances in 2.9 percent of alliance member-years.⁵⁶ In other words, while the baseline rate of alliance violation is relatively low, extremely polarized democracies appear to be two to three times more likely to violate alliances on average.

The results of models 5 and 6 are inconclusive, largely because they hinge on just a few alliance violations within democracies.⁵⁷ Nevertheless, they demonstrate the plausibility of hypotheses outlined in chapter 2. The primary takeaway from this set of analyses is that, while there is considerable evidence for the democratic advantages, variation in the behavior of democracies likely arises from different degrees of polarization. In the models presented in this chapter, not all coefficients on indicators of extreme polarization were significantly associated with the respective foreign policy outcomes. However, the results collectively suggest that, to the extent extreme polarization plays a role in shaping foreign policy, the effects are more likely to be negative than positive. This dynamic warrants a closer look, particularly given concerns about rising polarization in many advanced democracies around the world.

3.5 Conclusion

This chapter drew on an original dataset tracking the political party and ideological positions of the executive and the opposition parties in fifty-five democracies from 1945 to 2020. The dataset was developed with a crosswalk of the Archigos leader project and MARPOR on party platforms. I used the data to develop measures of extreme polarization on both a right–left

56. This interpretation uses a “typical” case of an alliance partnership involving one major and one minor power, which consists of a treaty that requires domestic ratification.

57. In models 5 and 6, factors like the change in international power, the presence of a new outside alliance, and the asymmetry of power between alliance partners appear highly correlated with alliance violations. This is driven by the fact that there are relatively few alliance violations in this smaller sample of democracies.

and a hawk–dove spectrum that reflected partisan divergence on liberal–conservative ideology and relative hawkishness in foreign affairs, respectively. I then incorporated these measures into foundational models of the democratic advantage in international relations. This exercise serves as a plausibility probe to motivate investigating the relationship between extreme polarization and the democratic advantages.

The first set of analyses focused on the stability advantage: the fact that democracies tend to maintain consistent foreign policy despite leader turnover. Using measures of country-level foreign policy positions constructed from roll-call votes in UNGA, I first replicated results from Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll that supported the stability advantage, showing that democracies tend to have more stable foreign policies than nondemocracies.⁵⁸ Then, introducing new measures of extreme polarization, I demonstrated that democracies experiencing high levels of hawk–dove polarization appeared to have greater instability in foreign policy relative to other democracies.

The second set of analyses focused on the credibility advantage: the ability of democracies to issue credible coercive threats to their foreign adversaries. I replicated and extended findings from Kenneth Schultz's classic models of reciprocation in militarized interstate disputes.⁵⁹ Schultz shows that because threats issued by democracies tend to be perceived as credible, the targets in a dispute are less likely to take military actions in response to coercive demands made by democracies. An extension of Schultz's analyses showed that when democracies experiencing extreme hawk–dove polarization initiated disputes, their targets were more likely to respond with threats or displays of force. This finding suggests that extremely polarized democracies could be perceived as less credible.

The final set of analyses investigated the reliability advantage: the ability of democracies to maintain their international commitments and be perceived as reliable partners. For these analyses, I extended research by Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel on alliance violations.⁶⁰ Replicating results from these researchers, I showed that democracies tend to be less likely to violate alliance commitments than nondemocracies. However, democracies experiencing extreme right–left polarization may be more likely to violate alliance commitments relative to their less polarized democratic peers.

58. Mattes, Leeds, and Carroll 2015.

59. Schultz 2001a.

60. Leeds, Mattes, and Vogel 2009.

There are limitations to these analyses. Most importantly, the measures used in cross-national analyses of polarization are imperfect. It is difficult to construct reliable and valid measures of polarization that enable comparisons across different contexts and political systems. We also lack reliable longitudinal data on affective polarization that could help us evaluate the behavior of extremely polarized democracies (i.e., democracies that experience high levels of ideological and affective polarization concurrently). Moreover, the outcome variables that we can observe cross-nationally, such as military actions taken during interstate disputes or violations of alliance agreements, focus on large changes in foreign policy behavior. Other important changes in foreign policy are not captured by these measures. Given the limitations of the data, many of the key results in these analyses are driven by only a few cases.

The evidence presented in this chapter is not definitive. Rather, this chapter serves as a plausibility probe to examine the relationship between extreme polarization and democratic advantages. Since polarization is a multicausal and structural phenomenon, descriptive analyses cannot isolate the causal effect of polarization on a given foreign policy outcome. However, since foundational scholarship in the democratic advantage tradition relies on cross-national analyses of regime type and foreign policy outcomes, this approach is a useful starting point. It further motivates careful within-case analysis of the relationship between polarization and foreign policy. The three remaining empirical chapters focus on the case of contemporary U.S. foreign policy, illustrating the logic behind each of the three democratic advantages and describing how these advantages are eroded by extreme forms of polarization in practice.